The Prompt Guide

How to write precise, structured prompts for Opus 5.5 and Grok that turn your real experience into strong applications, supporting statements, letters and interview answers

A PROMPT, X RAYED

<role> Experienced NHS sift panel member </role>
<person_spec> every essential criterion </person_spec>
<my_evidence> real examples, real numbers </my_evidence>
<rules> British English, first person, no invented facts </rules>

104
real UK job adverts decoded

70+
copy and paste prompts

11
sectors, from NHS to tech

0
technical knowledge needed

THE ROUTE MAP

Eight stops on the journey from blank screen to job offer

SLIDES 1 TO 9

Opening

How AI writing works, the honesty line, and how sift panels really score you.

SLIDES 10 TO 31

Part 1 · Structure

The eight building blocks of a precise prompt, the master template and the evidence bank.

SLIDES 32 TO 44

Part 2 · Opus 5.5 and Grok

How each model reads a prompt, matching templates, and how to use both together.

SLIDES 45 TO 105

Part 3 · 104 adverts

Real UK vacancies decoded sector by sector, each with a tailored prompt.

SLIDES 106 TO 131

Part 4 · Letters

Cover letters, CVs, offers, resignations, appeals, grants, UCAS and PhD statements.

SLIDES 132 TO 148

Part 5 · Interviews

Question banks, STAR builders, mock panels and debriefs for every UK format.

SLIDES 149 TO 155

Part 6 · Advanced

Prompt chains, sift simulators, voice matching, repairs and the quick reference card.

SLIDES 156 TO 160

Appendix

The full index of all 104 adverts studied, with employer and what each one asked for.

Short on time? Read slides 20, 21, 35 and 39, then jump straight to your sector in Part 3.

WHO THIS GUIDE IS FOR

Written for people who have never written a prompt in their life

THE NERVOUS FIRST TIMER

“I typed ‘write me a supporting statement’ and got something that sounded like a robot reading a brochure.”

You will learn why that happens and the five lines that fix it.

THE CAREER CHANGER

“My experience is real, but it is in a different sector. I cannot make it sound relevant.”

You will learn evidence mapping: translating what you did into what they score.

THE BUSY APPLICANT

“I apply for ten jobs a week. I need a system, not a blank page every time.”

You will build a reusable evidence bank and a personal prompt library.

What you need

A phone or computer · access to Opus 5.5 (in the Claude app) or Grok · your CV or a rough list of jobs you have done · the full job advert and person specification · about 30 minutes per application, falling to 10 once your evidence bank exists

HOW AI WRITING ACTUALLY WORKS

The model can only build with the bricks you hand it

YOU SUPPLY

- The full job advert
- The person specification
- Your real experience
- Rules: length, tone, format

THE MODEL DOES

Predicts the most likely helpful words, one after another, guided by everything in your message. It is brilliant at shaping, ordering and polishing. It cannot know what you did last Tuesday.

YOU RECEIVE

A draft that is only as specific, honest and relevant as the material it was given.

WHEN BRICKS ARE MISSING

The model fills gaps with plausible guesses. In a job application, a plausible guess is a false claim with your name on it.

THE RULE THAT FOLLOWS

Spend most of your effort on the input. Ten minutes gathering evidence beats an hour rewording a vague draft.

PLAIN ENGLISH GLOSSARY

Eight words you will meet in this guide

Prompt

Everything you type to the AI: the instruction plus all the material you paste in.

Role

The expert you ask the AI to act as, such as “an NHS sift panel member”. It sets standards and vocabulary.

Context

The background: who you are, what the job is, why it matters, who will read the result.

Constraint

A rule the answer must obey: a 500 word limit, British spelling, no bullet points.

Example

A short sample of the style you want. One good example often steers better than ten adjectives.

Tags

Labels in angle brackets, like <job_advert>, that fence off each part so nothing gets mixed up.

Iteration

Improving the draft through follow up messages: “shorter”, “more evidence on criterion 3”.

Hallucination

When the AI states something untrue with confidence. Your strongest defence is a rule forbidding invented facts.

Two more you will see: person specification (the list of essential and desirable criteria the panel scores) and **sift** (the shortlisting stage where your written statement is marked).

THE HONESTY LINE

UK employers are now writing AI rules into their adverts

NHS TRUST · MEDICAL SECRETARY

A Dorset HealthCare advert says AI may be used to enhance an application but not to create the supporting statement in its entirety, and warns that a statement which does not match the applicant's experience may lead to the application being withdrawn.

COUNCIL · SOCIAL WORKER

Stockport Council says it embraces AI as a tool for its own services, yet it is looking for authenticity in the applications it receives.

POLICE · APPLICATION GUIDANCE

Dorset Police guidance states that the application must be the candidate's own work, and the Civil Service reminds every candidate that it values honesty and integrity.

THIS GUIDE'S RULE

You are the author. The AI is your editor and coach.

- Every fact, example and number comes from you
- Every prompt in this deck forbids invented claims and marks gaps instead
- You should be able to talk about every sentence at interview
- If a form asks whether you used AI, answer truthfully

INSIDE THE SIFT

A sift panel marks evidence against a list, not the beauty of your prose

WHAT THE ADVERTS TOLD US

- NHS Lothian: you must show every essential criterion; when volume is high, desirable criteria decide the shortlist
- Brighton and Hove: the supporting statement is the most important part of the application
- Fife Council: no statement means the application does not progress, and a CV is not a statement
- Birmingham City Council: no statement attached, no consideration
- Lancaster University: statements are scored as part of shortlisting
- Durham Constabulary: weak evidence against the framework is not shortlisted

A TYPICAL MARKING GRID

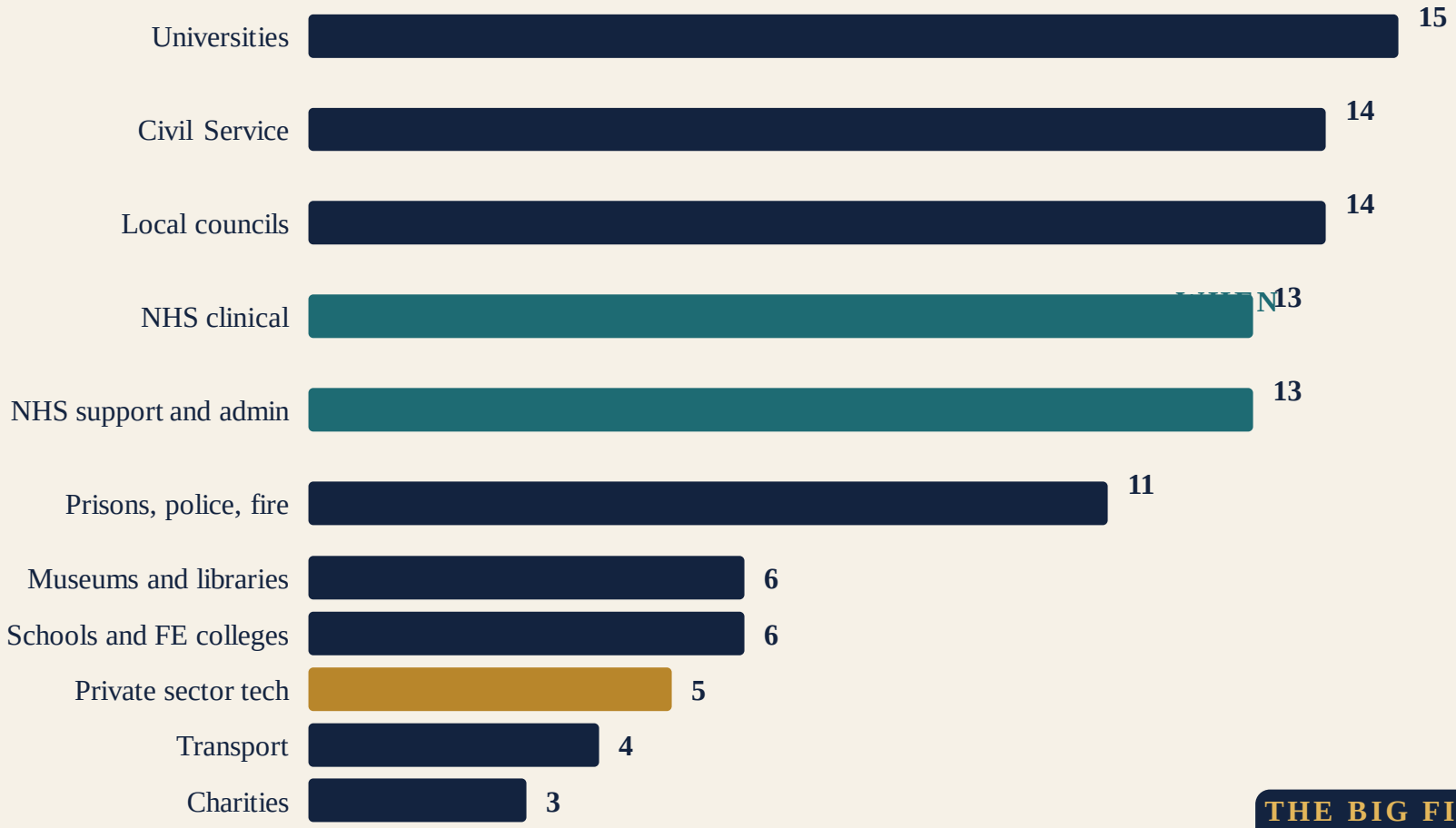
Criterion	Score
E1 Communication	Evidence clear · 3 of 3
E2 Teamwork	Asserted only · 1 of 3
E3 IT systems	Missing · 0 of 3
D1 Sector knowledge	Partial · 2 of 3

The lesson: one missing criterion can sink a beautifully written statement. Your prompt must force the AI to cover every criterion, in order, with evidence.

The grid above is an illustration. Civil Service behaviours are commonly scored on a 1 to 7 scale; other employers use their own scales.

THE RESEARCH AT A GLANCE

104 real UK adverts studied across 11 sectors



WHERE THEY CAME FROM

NHS Jobs, Civil Service Jobs, HMRC and Justice careers, council portals, Teaching Vacancies, jobs.ac.uk, university job sites, CharityJob, Find a Job and recruiter listings.

Mostly 2025 and 2026 campaigns. Many have closed; the requirements still show how each sector recruits.

THE BIG FINDING

Most public sector adverts demand a written statement mapped to named criteria. Generic text fails them all.

WHAT THE ADVERTS DEMANDED

From 150 words to two pages: the length is part of the brief

150 words
each competency, Police Scotland staff

250 words
one behaviour, DWP Work Coach

500 words
HMRC and DWP statements

750 words
MoJ Data Scientist, HMRC hub

750 to 1000
Manchester City Council advisor

1500 words
Birmingham housing post

SHAPES OF ASK

One behaviour · criteria in order · set questions · open “about you” · application form only, no CVs · CV plus statement

NO STATED LIMIT

Most NHS and university adverts set none. Aim for complete and concise: every criterion, nothing padded.

PROMPT HABIT

Always state the exact limit and ask the AI to report its word count at the end, then check it yourself.

PART ONE

1

The Structure of a precise prompt

Eight building blocks, one master template, and the habits that separate a vague request from a brief a professional would be proud of.

Role | Goal | Context | Source material | Evidence | Constraints | Format | **Quality check**

Every strong prompt answers eight questions before the AI writes a word

01

Role

Who should the AI be while it helps you?

02

Goal

What exactly must exist when it finishes?

03

Context

Who are you, who reads it, and what is at stake?

04

Source material

Which documents must it read in full?

05

Evidence

Which true stories and numbers may it use?

06

Constraints

Which rules can never be broken?

07

Format

What shape must the answer take?

08

Quality check

How should it test its own work before handing it over?



Memory trick: **R G C S E C F Q**, or “Really Good Candidates Show Evidence, Clearly Formatted, Quality checked.”

BLOCK 01 · ROLE

Give the AI a seat at the panel table, not a pen in a factory

WEAK

You are a helpful writer.

STRONG

You are a senior recruiting manager in an NHS acute trust who has shortlisted hundreds of Band 5 nursing applications. You know what scores and what gets skipped. You also coach applicants to write honestly in their own voice.

WHY IT WORKS

- Names the sector and seniority, so the vocabulary fits
- Gives the AI the scorer's view, not just the writer's
- Adds a coaching duty, which keeps your voice in the draft

Swap kit: Civil Service sift panel member · council HR shortlister · university head of department · charity service manager · technical hiring lead

Anthropic's own prompting guidance notes that setting a role focuses Claude's behaviour and tone for the task.

BLOCK 02 · GOAL

Describe the finished object, not the activity

WEAK

Help me with my application.

STRONG

Produce a supporting statement of no more than 750 words that shows, criterion by criterion, how my experience meets every essential requirement in the person specification below, ready to paste into the NHS Jobs supporting information box.

THE GOAL CHECKLIST

- ✓ What is the object? Statement, letter, answer
- ✓ How big is it? Words or characters
- ✓ What must it prove? Every essential criterion
- ✓ Where will it live? Portal box, email, PDF

Why it works: a finished object gives the AI a finish line. “Help me” invites chat; “produce a 750 word statement that proves criteria 1 to 8” produces a deliverable.

BLOCK 03 · CONTEXT

Tell the AI the story around the task

YOU

Current role, years, sector, the move you are making, any gap or change to explain

THE READER

Sift panel, hiring manager, admissions tutor, landlord, HR officer

THE STAKES

First Band 5 post, a promotion, a career change, a second attempt after rejection

YOUR LIMITS

English as a second language, no sector jargon yet, a tight deadline tonight

WEAK

I am applying for a nursing job.

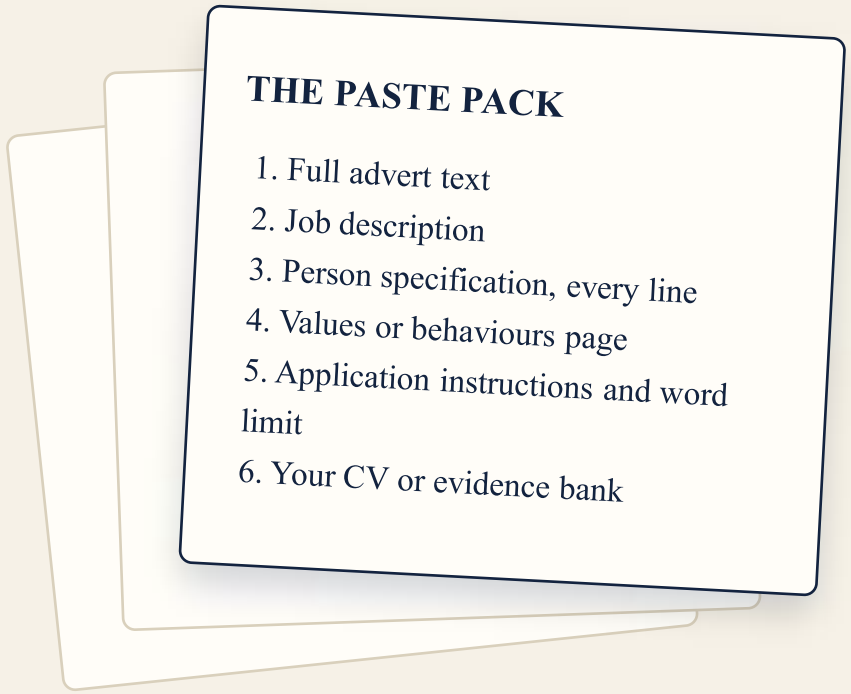
STRONG

I qualified as a registered nurse in July and spent three years before that as a healthcare assistant on an acute medical ward. This is my first Band 5 application. The reader is a ward manager shortlisting about 40 applicants. English is my second language, so keep sentences plain and natural.

Why it works: the same facts land differently for a newly qualified nurse and for a returning matron. Context tells the AI which angle to lead with and which gaps to handle with care.

BLOCK 04 · SOURCE MATERIAL

Paste the documents in full. Never summarise them yourself.



The trap: BHRUT nursing adverts warn that the criteria shown on the advert page are not the full specification. The rest sits in the attached job description. Paste only the advert and the AI will miss criteria.

The fix: open the attached PDF or Word file, copy every line, and paste it inside its own labelled block.

Order matters: Anthropic’s guidance for long inputs is to place long documents near the top of the prompt, above your instructions and question.

BLOCK 05 · EVIDENCE

Raw, specific, true: the fuel every good statement burns

ASSERTION, SCORES LOW

I have excellent communication skills and work well under pressure.

EVIDENCE NOTE, SCORES HIGH

March 2026, matchday till at Old Trafford: card reader failed with a queue of about 30 fans. I switched to the backup terminal, kept the queue updated every few minutes and called the supervisor. No complaints; my supervisor thanked me in the debrief.

You do not need polished sentences. Notes like this are perfect input; the AI does the polishing.

FIVE THINGS EVERY NOTE NEEDS

1. When and where it happened
2. The problem or task you faced
3. What you personally did, step by step
4. A result, ideally a number
5. Proof: feedback, an award, a reference, a certificate

BLOCK 06 · CONSTRAINTS

Guardrails: the rules the AI may never break

PROMPT · THE STANDARD GUARDRAIL BLOCK

Rules you must follow:

1. Use British English spelling and UK workplace terms.
2. Write in the first person singular. Say “I”, never “we”, when describing my actions.
3. Use only facts from my evidence. If a criterion has no evidence, write [GAP: what is missing] instead of inventing anything.
4. Stay under [500] words and tell me the final word count.
5. Avoid clichés such as “passionate”, “dynamic”, “go the extra mile”.
6. Use plain sentences of no more than 25 words.
7. Do not repeat my CV line by line; explain how and why.

RULE 2 MATTERS

Civil Service guidance warns that markers can only score your individual contribution. “We” hides you.

RULE 3 IS SACRED

The [GAP] marker turns invention into a to do list. You fill the gap, or you decide to leave it.

Number your rules. Numbered rules are easier for you to check, and easier to point at later: “you broke rule 4”.

BLOCK 07 · FORMAT

Draw the shape of the answer before it is written

FOR A PORTAL TEXT BOX

Plain paragraphs only. No bold, no bullet symbols, no tables: many portals strip formatting. Use short criterion labels in capitals instead of headings.

FOR AN UPLOADED DOCUMENT

A heading per criterion, your name and the job reference at the top, page numbers, and two pages at most unless told otherwise.

FOR AN EMAIL OR LETTER

Subject line, greeting, three short paragraphs, sign off, and your contact details beneath your name.

PROMPT · A FORMAT BLOCK YOU CAN REUSE

Format the answer like this: one opening paragraph of up to 80 words on why I want this role · then, for each essential criterion in order, a label in capitals followed by one paragraph using the STAR method · one closing paragraph of up to 60 words · then a separate checking table with three columns: criterion, evidence used, strength from 1 to 5. Do not use bold or bullet symbols in the statement itself because it will be pasted into a plain text box.

Anthropic's guidance adds a subtle point: the formatting style of your prompt influences the style of the reply. A prompt full of bullets tends to get bullets back.

BLOCK 08 · QUALITY CHECK

Make the AI mark its own homework before it hands it in

PROMPT · SELF CHECK BLOCK

Before you give me the final version, check it against these tests and fix anything that fails:

1. Is every essential criterion addressed, in order, by name?
2. Does every claim appear in my evidence? Remove anything that does not.
3. Is it written as “I”, with my actions clearly separated from the team’s?
4. Is it within the word limit? State the count.
5. Would a tired panel member find the evidence for each criterion within ten seconds?

After the statement, list the [GAP] items and the two weakest criteria with a suggestion for each.

THE TEN SECOND TEST

Panels read many statements in one sitting. If the evidence for a criterion is buried in paragraph four, it may never be found.

Still read it yourself. A self check reduces errors; it does not remove them. You are the final quality check.

THE MASTER TEMPLATE · COPY, FILL THE BRACKETS, PASTE

One prompt that handles almost any supporting statement

Works in Opus 5.5 and Grok

<role> You are a senior UK recruiting manager in [sector] who has shortlisted hundreds of applications for roles like this, and a writing coach who keeps applicants in their own voice. </role>

<job_advert> [Paste the full advert text] </job_advert>

<person_specification> [Paste every essential and desirable criterion exactly as written, including how each is assessed] </person_specification>

<my_evidence> [Paste your CV and your evidence notes: dates, places, actions, results, feedback] </my_evidence>

<context> I am [your situation in two sentences]. The reader is [who shortlists]. </context>

<task> Write my supporting statement. Address every essential criterion in the order listed, then desirable criteria where I have evidence. </task>

<rules> 1. British English. 2. First person “I”. 3. Use only facts in my evidence; where none exists write [GAP: what is missing]. 4. Maximum [750] words. 5. One STAR example for each major criterion. 6. No clichés; sentences under 25 words. </rules>

<format> A short opening on motivation, a capitalised label and one paragraph per criterion, a short close. Then, separately, a table: criterion, evidence used, strength 1 to 5. </format>

<check> Before replying, confirm every essential criterion is covered, every fact is in my evidence, and the word count is within limit. End with a list of [GAP] items and the two weakest criteria. </check>

THE MASTER TEMPLATE · X RAY VIEW

What each block of the master template is doing for you

1 **<role> · two hats**
Scorer's eye plus coach's restraint: it knows what earns marks and keeps your voice.

2 **<job_advert> · the brief**
Full text, so it picks up the employer's language, values and priorities.

3 **<person_specification> · the marking scheme**
The single most important paste. "How assessed" tells it which criteria the statement must prove.

4 **<my_evidence> · the only allowed facts**
Fences the truth. Rule 3 then forbids anything from outside this fence.

5 **<context> · the angle**
Career changer, returner or internal candidate: each needs a different lead.

6 **<task> · the finish line**
"In the order listed" mirrors the panel's scoring sheet line for line.

7 **<rules> and <format> · the guardrails**
Numbered, so you can enforce them later: "rewrite, you broke rule 4".

8 **<check> · the inspector**
Turns one shot writing into write, test, fix. The gap list becomes your homework.

The tags themselves: Anthropic's documentation says there are no special magic tag names. What matters is that each name makes sense for what it wraps, and that you use the same names consistently.

BUILD ONCE, USE FOREVER · THE EVIDENCE BANK

Turn a messy brain dump into a reusable bank of proof

PROMPT · EVIDENCE BANK BUILDER

<role> You are a patient UK career coach who turns rough notes into interview ready evidence. </role>
<raw_notes> [Dump everything: every job and dates, duties, problems you solved, things you are proud of, numbers, compliments, complaints you handled, training, volunteering] </raw_notes>
<task> Organise my notes into separate STAR stories. For each story give: a short title, date and place, situation, task, my actions as numbered steps, result with any numbers, proof, and the skills it could evidence (communication, teamwork, leadership, problem solving, customer service, safeguarding, working with data, adapting to change). </task>
<rules> Do not add or improve any fact. If part of a story is missing, do not guess: list a question for me under QUESTIONS at the end. </rules>

STEP 2

Answer its QUESTIONS in a reply. Ask it to update the stories.

STEP 3

Save the final bank as a document. Paste it into <my_evidence> for every application.

Aim for 12 to 15 stories. That covers almost every criterion in every advert in Part 3.

THE STORYTELLING FRAMES

STAR, CAR and STARR: pick the frame that fits the word limit

S
Situation
about 15%

T
Task
10%

A
Action · about 55% · your steps, your decisions, your skills. This is where the marks live.

R
Result · about 20% · numbers, outcomes, feedback

STAR · THE DEFAULT

Used for Civil Service behaviours, police and council criteria. Civil Service guidance urges putting most of your word count into the actions.

CAR · FOR TIGHT LIMITS

Context, Action, Result. Merges situation and task. Ideal for the 150 and 250 word boxes.

STARR · FOR REFLECTIVE ROLES

Adds Reflection: what you learned and changed. Fits nursing, social work, teaching and coaching roles.

Prompt line to add: “Use the [STAR / CAR / STARR] structure for each example and spend roughly half the words on what I personally did.”

LIMITS CHEAT SHEET

Real limits from real adverts, and how to brief the AI on each

Employer and role	Limit	Brief the AI with
Police Scotland staff post	150 per competency	CAR, one example each
DWP Bilingual Work Coach	250, one behaviour	One STAR story only
HMRC Payments Officer	500	Two or three examples
DWP Universal Credit Work Coach	500, one behaviour	One deep STAR story
Ministry of Justice Data Scientist	750, anonymised	Criteria order, no names
Manchester City Council advisor	750 to 1000	Cover each listed area
Birmingham housing officer	1500	Every criterion in depth
NHS supporting information	Set by the portal	Check the box limit first

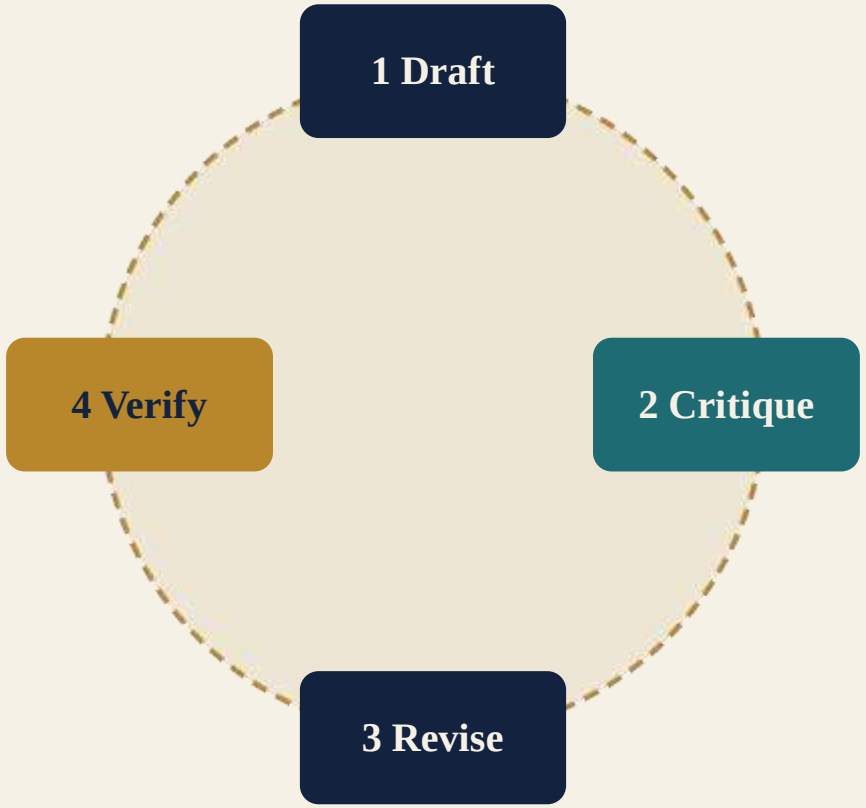
COUNTING TRUTH

AI word counts are estimates. Always paste the result into a word counter, or the portal box, before you submit.

Characters, not words? Ask for “no more than [N] characters including spaces”, then aim about 10% under to leave room for edits.

THE ITERATION LOOP

The first draft is a starting point. The third draft gets interviews.



FOLLOW UP MESSAGES THAT WORK

- “Criterion 3 is weak. Use my rota story instead and rewrite only that paragraph.”
- “Act as the panel. Score each criterion 1 to 5 and explain every score under 4.”
- “Cut 120 words without removing any evidence. Show me what you cut.”
- “This sounds too formal for me. Make it plainer, like I speak at work.”

> Avoid “make it better”. Say what is wrong and where.

TECHNIQUE · INTERVIEW ME FIRST

Stuck for examples? Let the AI ask the questions

PROMPT · THE INTERVIEWER

I am applying for the job below and I struggle to think of examples.

<person_specification> [paste] </person_specification>

Do not write anything for the application yet. Instead, interview me. Ask me one question at a time, starting with the first essential criterion. Ask about real situations from my work, studies, volunteering or home life. When my answer is vague, ask a follow up question to get the date, my exact actions and the result. After every three criteria, show me a short summary of the evidence you have collected so far. When all criteria are covered, give me the complete evidence list, and only then offer to draft the statement.

WHY ONE AT A TIME

Twenty questions at once feels like a form. One at a time feels like a conversation, and memories come back.

WHY "HOME LIFE"

Caring for a relative, running a community group or managing a household budget can evidence real criteria, especially for entry level roles.

Voice tip: both apps let you speak your answers. Talking often unlocks better stories than typing.

TECHNIQUE · ANONYMISED APPLICATIONS

When the panel must not know who you are

WHAT THE ADVERTS SAID

The Ministry of Justice Data Scientist adverts asked candidates to keep their name and any other identifying details out of both CV and personal statement. Single Homeless Project asked for an anonymised CV. TfGM warned that personal details left in would be visible to the hiring manager.

The hidden risk: AI drafts love vivid detail, so they slip in your employer's name, your university or your town. Each one can identify you.

PROMPT · ANONYMITY RULE BLOCK

This application is assessed anonymously. In the statement:
1. Never include my name, age, gender, nationality or address.
2. Replace employer names with descriptions, for example "a large NHS acute trust" or "a national retailer".
3. Replace university and school names with the qualification and grade.
4. Remove town and street names unless the advert asks for location.
5. After the statement, list every phrase you anonymised so I can check nothing identifying remains.

TECHNIQUE · BRITISH ENGLISH AND YOUR OWN VOICE

Sound like a capable person from Britain, not a brochure

SPELLING AND TERMS

American	British
organize	organise
program	programme
resume	CV
coworkers	colleagues
vacation	annual leave

WORDS THAT SIGNAL AI

delve · tapestry · testament · seamless · leverage · in today's fast paced world · I am thrilled · not only but also, used everywhere · unwavering commitment

Ban the ones you would never say out loud.

PROMPT · VOICE MATCH

Here are two paragraphs I wrote myself: [paste]. Match my vocabulary, sentence length and tone. Keep the grammar correct, but do not make me sound grander than I am. Avoid these words: [list].

Why voice matters: the panel will meet you. If your statement sounds like a stranger, the gap shows at interview. Grok guidance from users also stresses giving a sample of your desired output so it can copy tone, structure and rhythm.

THE FAILURE GALLERY

Eight ways AI applications fail, and the line that prevents each

Generic
Could fit any job.
Fix: paste the full person spec.

Invented
Numbers you never achieved.
Fix: the [GAP] rule.

Hidden in “we”
The team did everything.
Fix: “I” for my actions.

Criterion missed
One essential skipped.
Fix: “in the order listed” plus a check.

Buzzword soup
Passionate, dynamic, synergy.
Fix: a banned word list.

Too long
Rejected by the portal.
Fix: hard limit plus your own count.

CV repeated
Duties, no proof.
Fix: “explain how, not what”.

Not you
Polished, but a stranger.
Fix: a voice sample.

The pattern: every failure is an instruction you did not give. Good prompting is mostly closing doors before the AI walks through them.

PRIVACY FIRST

What never goes into a prompt

KEEP OUT

- National Insurance, passport or driving licence numbers
- Bank, card or payroll details
- Your full date of birth and home address
- Patient, client, pupil or customer names and identifying details
- Referees' phone numbers and emails
- Confidential documents from your current employer

SAFE SWAPS

"Mrs Ahmed in bed 4" becomes "an older patient with limited English". "Acme Logistics Ltd" becomes "a regional logistics firm" if you prefer. Placeholders such as [REFEREE 1] keep the structure.

CHECK YOUR SETTINGS

Both apps offer settings that control how your chats and files are stored. Look at them once, and delete old uploads you no longer need.

Clinical and care roles: confidentiality is often an essential criterion. A statement that leaks a patient detail fails that criterion on sight.

PREFLIGHT CHECKLIST

Twelve ticks before you press send on any prompt

- Role names the sector and seniority
- Goal describes a finished object and size
- Full advert pasted, not summarised
- Every person spec line pasted
- Evidence bank or CV included
- Context: who I am, who reads it
- Exact word or character limit stated
- No invented facts rule, with [GAP]
- British English and first person “I”
- Format suits the portal or document
- Self check block at the end
- Nothing private or identifying pasted

Photograph this slide. It is the whole of Part 1 on one screen.

PART TWO

2

Opus 5.5 and Grok: two minds, two ways to brief them

The same eight blocks work in both. What changes is the packaging: tidy labelled sections for Opus 5.5, clear and direct conversation for Grok.

Opus 5.5 · Anthropic · in the Claude app

Grok · xAI · in the Grok app and on X

Think of a meticulous editor and a quick witted researcher

Opus 5.5

THE METICULOUS EDITOR

- Responds very well to clearly labelled sections, such as tags
- Strong at reading long adverts and job packs in full
- Follows numbered rules and length limits closely
- Good at flagging gaps honestly when you ask it to
- Learns style quickly from examples you wrap in example tags

Best for: the final statement, letters, careful edits

Grok

THE QUICK WITTED RESEARCHER

- Community guides say it works best with direct, conversational prompts
- Can pull in current web results and posts on X
- Gives blunt, opinionated feedback when asked
- Has a playful default personality, so ask for a formal register
- Copies tone and rhythm well from a sample you provide

Best for: employer research, blunt critique, brainstorming

These are tendencies, not laws. Both models can do every task in this deck; the tips simply raise your odds of a great firstdraft.

Tags are labelled envelopes: nothing spills into anything else

<job_advert>
What the employer wrote

<person_spec>
How you will be scored

<my_evidence>
The only allowed facts

<example>
Style to copy, not content

WHAT ANTHROPIC'S GUIDANCE SAYS

- Tags help Claude separate instructions, context, examples and inputs
- There are no special tag names; choose names that describe the contents
- Use the same tag names throughout, and nest them when it helps
- Wrap examples in example tags so they are not mistaken for instructions

How to type one: a less than sign, a short name with underscores instead of spaces, a greater than sign. Close it the same way with a slash: </job_advert>.

Then point at them: "Using only the facts in <my_evidence>, address each criterion in <person_spec>."

Documents first, instructions second, answers in labelled boxes

Opus 5.5

<job_advert> [full advert] </job_advert>

<person_spec> [every criterion, with essential, desirable and how assessed] </person_spec>

<my_evidence> [evidence bank or CV] </my_evidence>

<voice_sample> [two paragraphs you wrote yourself] </voice_sample>

<example> [one paragraph of a statement style you like] </example>

You are a senior UK [sector] recruiting manager and an honest writing coach. Using the advert in <job_advert> and the criteria in <person_spec>, write my supporting statement using only facts from <my_evidence>. Match the vocabulary and sentence length of <voice_sample>. Copy the structure of <example>, never its content.

<rules> 1. British English. 2. “I” for my actions. 3. No fact outside <my_evidence>; mark gaps as [GAP: …]. 4. Under [750] words. 5. STAR for each essential criterion, in order. 6. Plain text, no bold, for a portal box. </rules>

First, inside <plan> tags, list each criterion and the evidence story you will use for it. Then write the statement inside <statement> tags. Finally, inside <checks> tags, give the word count, a table of criterion, evidence and strength from 1 to 5, and every [GAP].

Six design decisions inside that template

A

Long material on top

Anthropic advises placing long documents above the instructions. The model reads the whole pack before it is told what to do with it.

B

Two kinds of sample

The voice sample shapes how it sounds; the example shapes structure. Separating them stops your old content leaking in.

C

Instructions name tags

“Using only facts from <my_evidence>” draws a hard line around what may be claimed.

D

A plan before prose

Mapping criteria to stories first catches a missing criterion before 700 words are spent.

E

Output in boxes

<statement> is what you paste; <checks> is for you only. No accidental pasting of notes.

F

Plain text rule

Portals often strip formatting. Asking for plain text avoids stray symbols in your submitted statement.

OPUS 5.5 · TWO POWER MOVES

Feed it the whole job pack, then show it what good looks like

Power move 1 · Several documents

```
<documents>
<document><source>Job description.pdf</source>
<document_content> [paste] </document_content></document>
<document><source>Trust values page</source> …
</documents>
```

This mirrors Anthropic's own advice for many documents: wrap each one, with its source as a label. Then add: "Quote the exact criterion wording from the documents before you address it."

Power move 2 · Examples that steer

```
<examples>
<example> TEAMWORK. In 2025 I noticed … I arranged … As a result …
</example>
<example> PLANNING. When our rota … I … which meant … </example>
</examples>
```

Anthropic calls examples one of the most reliable ways to steer format, tone and structure. Two or three varied examples work better than one, so the model copies the pattern rather than the details.

Easy version: you can also simply attach the PDF job pack in the Claude app and write "The attached file is the job pack" inside your prompt.

Talk to Grok like a sharp colleague: direct, specific, fenced in

Conversational

Community guides report Grok does best with natural, flowing prompts. Plain capital headings like JOB ADVERT: work well.

Direct

It responds well to bluntness. Say exactly what you want and what you do not want, without polite padding.

Connected

It can pull in current web results and posts on X. Great for employer research, but tell it when not to search.

Personality

Its default style can be witty. For applications, ask for a plain, professional British register.

Imitates samples

Give it a sample and it studies tone, structure and rhythm. Your own writing is the best sample.

Fence the length

Users report that clear length fences stop it writing far more than you need. Always state the limit.

xAI publishes less prompting guidance than Anthropic, so these points draw on courses and community guides as well as hands on practice. Test and adjust.

Same eight blocks, written as a straight talking brief

Grok

Grok, I need a formal, honest supporting statement for a UK job. Drop the jokes and write in a plain, professional British register. Do not search the web for this one; use only what I give you.

THE JOB ADVERT: [paste the full advert]

THE PERSON SPECIFICATION, WHICH IS HOW I WILL BE SCORED: [paste every criterion]

MY REAL EXPERIENCE. USE NOTHING ELSE: [paste evidence bank or CV]

HOW I WRITE: [two paragraphs of your own writing]. Copy this tone.

WHAT I WANT: a statement of no more than [750] words in the first person. Go through each essential criterion in order. For each, give one real example: situation, task, what I did, result.

HARD RULES: no invented facts. If I have no evidence for a criterion, write [GAP] and tell me what is missing. British spelling. No clichés. Plain text only.

AFTER THE STATEMENT: be brutally honest. Give the word count, name the three weakest parts and tell me what evidence would fix each one.

Why each line of the Grok brief is there

1. **“Drop the jokes”**
   Switches off the playful default before it colours your statement.
2. **“Do not search the web”**
   Keeps outside material, which may be about someone else, out of your personal statement.
3. **Capital headings with a reason**
   “Which is how I will be scored” tells it why this block matters most.
4. **“Use nothing else”**
   The honesty fence, written as plain speech.
5. **“Copy this tone”**
   Uses its strength at imitating rhythm and structure from samples.
6. **Hard fenced length**
   A clear limit prevents the essay that a Civil Service box would reject.
7. **“Brutally honest” critique**
   Turns its directness into your free second opinion.

Saves time: put lines 1, 2 and 7 in Grok’s custom instructions once, so every chat starts that way.

SIDE BY SIDE · ONE TASK, TWO PACKAGINGS

A 250 word Civil Service behaviour statement, briefed for each model

FOR OPUS 5.5

<behaviour> Communicating and Influencing, Level 2 </behaviour>
<level_descriptors> [paste from the Success Profiles page] </level_descriptors>
<my_story> [one evidence bank story] </my_story>
Act as a Civil Service sift panel member. Write a 250 word STAR example from <my_story> that shows the behaviours in <level_descriptors>. Put about 60% of the words on my actions. Use “I”. No new facts. Inside <statement> give the text; inside <checks> give the word count and which descriptors it evidences.

FOR GROK

I am applying to DWP and must write 250 words on the Civil Service behaviour Communicating and Influencing at Level 2. Here is what that level means: [paste]. Here is my real example: [paste]. Write it as STAR in the first person, with most of the words on what I did. No made up details, formal British English, no jokes. Then tell me straight: which parts of the level description did I prove, and which did I miss? Give the word count.

Same ingredients: role, behaviour, level, story, length, honesty rule, check.

Different wrapping: labelled boxes versus plain spoken sentences.

Which model to reach for, task by task

Task	Lead	Why
Final supporting statement	Opus 5.5	Tight rule following, long job packs, honest gap flags
Researching the employer	Grok	Current web results and public posts on X
Brutal critique of a draft	Grok	Direct, opinionated feedback on request
Formal letters and emails	Opus 5.5	Measured tone, consistent British register
Mock interview practice	Either	Both handle one question at a time well
Brainstorming examples	Grok	Fast, loose idea generation
Trimming to an exact limit	Opus 5.5	Cuts words while keeping every criterion
Academic or research statements	Opus 5.5	Handles dense papers and nuanced fit

Only have one? Use it for everything. The templates in this deck work in both; the “lead” column is a preference, not a requirement.

Let one model draft and the other attack, then finish with the first

LEG 1 · GROK
Research the employer: strategy, recent news, values, inspection reports.

→

LEG 2 · OPUS 5.5
Draft the statement with the master template plus a short research summary.

→

LEG 3 · GROK
Act as a sceptical panel: score it and list the weakest lines.

→

LEG 4 · OPUS 5.5
Revise using the critique, keeping every rule and the word limit.

PROMPT · LEG 3, THE SCEPTIC

You are a tough sift panel member for [employer]. Here is the person specification: [paste]. Here is a candidate's statement: [paste]. Score each essential criterion from 1 to 5. Quote the weakest sentence for each and say why it would lose marks. Do not rewrite it; just judge it.

Why "do not rewrite"? A critic who also rewrites tends to impose its own style. Keep the roles clean: one judges, the other edits, and you decide.

Small switches in each app that change the result

In the Claude app

Pick Opus 5.5

Use the model picker for heavy writing and careful edits.

Let it think

For long statements, ask it to plan first, or turn on extended thinking where your plan offers it.

Attach files

Upload the job pack PDF and your CV instead of pasting.

Projects and preferences

Keep your evidence bank in a project so every new chat can use it.

In the Grok app

Think mode

Useful when you want reasoning on a tricky criterion or a career change angle.

DeepSearch

For a structured research report on an employer before you write.

Custom instructions

Set once: British English, formal register, no jokes, honest critique.

Data controls

Review and delete files you have shared once an application is done.

Feature names and availability change and differ by subscription. If a switch is missing, the prompt alone still does most of the work.

PART THREE

3

104 real UK job adverts, decoded

For each sector: dossier cards on real vacancies, what that sector rewards, and a prompt tuned to its scoring system. Find your sector and start there.

NHS clinical · 49	NHS support · 55	Civil Service · 61	Justice, fire · 69
Councils · 76	Culture · 83	Universities · 86	Schools, FE · 93
Charities · 97	Transport · 97	**Private tech · 101**	Decoding · 46

Every advert has five layers. Most applicants only read the top one.



Layer 1 example: Manchester City Council asks for proof of Manchester residency on some lower grade roles.

Layer 4 example: TfGM's behaviours bring its values of Deliver, Care and Adapt to life.

Layer 5 example: "may close early if a high volume of applications are received" means apply in the first days.

PROMPT · THE ADVERT DECODER

Run this before you write a single word of any application

PROMPT · DECODE THIS ADVERT

<advert_pack> [paste advert, job description and person specification] </advert_pack>
<my_cv> [paste] </my_cv>
Act as an experienced UK recruiter. Decode this advert for me in plain English under these headings:
1. HARD FILTERS: anything that would rule me out, and whether my CV meets each.
2. SCORED CRITERIA: a table of every criterion, essential or desirable, how it is assessed, and my evidence strength: strong, partial or none.
3. FORMAT RULES: word limits, documents required, questions to answer, deadlines.
4. CULTURE SIGNALS: values and behaviours, quoted exactly.
5. HIDDEN PRIORITIES: words repeated three or more times, and what they suggest.
6. RISKS: anything unclear that I should ask the named contact about.
Do not write any application text yet.

Output use: the criteria table becomes your writing plan, and the "none" rows become your [GAP] list.

Go or no go: if a hard filter fails, you have saved an evening. If most criteria are partial, consider the informal chat many adverts offer.

Grok bonus: add "then search for recent news about this employer and summarise three points worth knowing."

WORKED EXAMPLE · DECODING A REAL ADVERT

Manchester City Council · Customer Service Centre Advisor

WHAT THE ADVERT SAID, PARAPHRASED

Based at a north Manchester neighbourhood office, the advisor is one of the main voices supporting residents across North Manchester. Applicants send a personal statement of 750 to 1000 words covering set areas, show how they meet the essential criteria, and state clearly whether they want the full time or part time post. The council's Our Manchester behaviours include working together and trusting each other, valuing differences and treating people fairly, and being proud and passionate about Manchester.

Filter: right to work; the advert says this role is not eligible for Skilled Worker sponsorship.

Format: 750 to 1000 words, the listed areas, plus the essential criteria.

Easy marks lost: forgetting to say full time or part time.

Culture: show trust, fairness and local pride with real moments.

Hidden priority: "key voice" means phone and face to face confidence with residents.

SECTOR 1

NHS clinical roles

Band 5 staff nurses to Band 7 specialist practitioners, across acute, community, mental health and children's services in England and Scotland.

Statement field: "supporting information" on NHS Jobs

Scored against: the person specification in the attached job description

Also weighed: trust values and professional codes

13

adverts studied

DOSSIER · NHS CLINICAL · ADVERTS 1 TO 7

Band 5 nursing: the person specification is the whole game

01 · Barking, Havering and Redbridge

Band 5 Staff Nurse, ward

Supporting information must show how you meet each criterion; the advert lists only part of the spec.

Hook: paste the full spec from the job description.

02 · Barking, Havering and Redbridge

Band 5 Staff Nurse, team

Same rule: read every supporting document before applying.

Hook: tell the AI the advert text is incomplete.

03 · University Hospitals Birmingham

Band 5 RN, infectious disease

Acute experience, phlebotomy, PICC line care, problem solving and competing demands.

Hook: one STAR story per named skill.

04 · NHS Lothian

Band 5 Staff Nurse, discharge hub

Meet all essentials; desirables decide busy shortlists. Each line says how it is assessed.

Hook: prioritise rows marked A.

05 · NHS Lothian

Staff Nurse, ENT outpatients

NMC registration and Code knowledge essential; CPD evidence desirable.

Hook: list CPD with dates and what changed.

06 · NHS Lothian

Care Home Team Staff Nurse

Must show board values: quality, compassion, dignity, openness, honesty, responsibility.

Hook: one real moment per value.

07 · NHS Lothian

Staff Nurse, general medicine

Team player, flexible, compassionate, at ease in a multidisciplinary team.

Hook: show behaviour, never list adjectives.

DECODER KEY

Lothian specs mark each line A, I or R: application, interview or references. Rows marked A must be proven in writing.

Band 6 and 7 specialists: judgement beats task lists

08 · Dorset HealthCare

Band 6 Specialist Practitioner

Care coordinator for complex needs: specialist training, Band 5 experience, clinical reasoning, driving licence.

Hook: show decisions, not duties.

09 · Berkshire Healthcare via NHSP

Band 6 Mental Health Practitioner

Communicate complex, sensitive news with empathy and reassurance.

Hook: one difficult conversation story.

10 · Sussex Partnership

Band 7 Specialist Practitioner

Neurodevelopmental service: autism and ADHD interest, autonomy, own diary, open to change.

Hook: evidence self directed caseload.

11 · Newcastle upon Tyne Hospitals

Nurse Specialist, Band 6 to 7

Band 6 entrants complete prescribing and clinical skills courses, then progress in about 18 months.

Hook: prove you learn fast.

12 · Crisis service, Devizes

Band 6 Intensive Practitioner

Triage, psychosocial assessment, Mental Health Act work, risk plans, least restrictive practice.

Hook: a risk story told as STARR.

13 · Nottinghamshire Healthcare

MHST Specialist Practitioner

Children and young people, one to one and group, whole school approach, driving licence.

Hook: school partnership evidence.

THE BAND LADDER

Band 5: safe, kind delivery.
Band 6: specialist judgement, leading shifts.
Band 7: expert lead, developing the service.

Rule of thumb: the higher the band, the more your statement must explain why you decided, not just what you did.

WHAT THE NHS REWARDS

Three pillars every NHS clinical statement must stand on

I

The person specification

Shortlisters work down the list, row by row. Every essential row assessed by application needs a sentence of proof you can point to.

II

Values

Each trust or board publishes its own values, and the NHS Constitution sets national ones such as compassion, respect and dignity, and everyone counts. Show them in action.

III

Professional standards

For nurses, the NMC Code: prioritise people, practise effectively, preserve safety, promote professionalism and trust. Other professions have their own codes.

Watch out: Dorset HealthCare now warns applicants against statements created entirely by AI. Use the prompts to shape your words, not replace them.

Easy win: reflection. A sentence on what you learned and now do differently signals a reflective practitioner.

PROMPT · NHS CLINICAL SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Row by row, value by value, patient safe

Adverts 1 to 13

<role> You are an NHS ward manager who shortlists Band 5 and 6 nurses and coaches applicants to write honestly. </role>
<job_pack> [advert, job description and full person specification, including how each row is assessed] </job_pack>
<trust_values> [paste the trust or board values page] </trust_values>
<my_evidence> [registration status, placements or posts, clinical skills with dates, CPD, feedback, anonymised examples] </my_evidence>
<task> Write my NHS Jobs supporting information. Work through the person specification row by row, starting with essential rows assessed by application. For each, write a short paragraph with one real example using STARR. Where it fits naturally, show which trust value or NMC Code theme the example reflects. </task>
<rules> 1. Never include patient names, ages, bed numbers or anything identifying. 2. Never claim a clinical skill or competency that is not in my evidence; write [GAP: skill] instead. 3. British English, first person, plain text paragraphs. 4. Stay under [limit] and report the count. 5. No clichés such as “passionate about patient care”. </rules>

<check> Afterwards list: rows with no evidence, rows with weak evidence, and confirmation that no patient detail appears. </check>

What the prompt protects, and what one good paragraph looks like

1. **Assessed by application first.** Mirrors how Lothian and others mark rows A, I or R.
2. **Trust values pasted, not guessed.** Each trust words them differently.
3. **STARR not STAR.** Reflection is the language of clinical practice and revalidation.
4. **Confidentiality rule first in the list.** A leak fails a core professional duty.
5. **No phantom skills.** Claiming PICC line care you have never done is unsafe and easily exposed.

TARGET SHAPE OF ONE PARAGRAPH

COMMUNICATION WITH FAMILIES. [Situation] On a final placement on an acute medical ward, [Task] I needed to explain a discharge plan to a relative with limited English. [Action] I booked a telephone interpreter, checked understanding using teach back… [Result] … [Reflection] I now …

The bracket labels are for you; ask the AI to remove them in the final version.

SECTOR 2

NHS support and administration

Healthcare support workers at Bands 2 and 3, and medical secretaries and team administrators at Band 4. The doorway into the NHS for career changers.

Big opportunity: several adverts welcome people new to care

Key skill: translating retail, hospitality or cleaning work into care language

Admin focus: accuracy, confidentiality, systems, terminology

13

adverts studied

Healthcare support workers: the door is open to newcomers

14 · Black Country Healthcare

HCSW Band 3, inpatients

Prior HCSW experience, strong communication, able to work alone and in a team.

Hook: one story for alone, one for team.

15 · Barts Health, Royal London

Senior HCSW, adult theatres

Open to experienced staff and to people new to care; nutrition and hydration support.

Hook: lead with transferable care.

16 · Barts Health, Newham

Senior HCSW, ward

Newcomers start on Band 2 pay while completing Band 3 competencies within six months.

Hook: prove you learn on the job.

17 · Birmingham, Heartlands

Band 2 or 3 HCA

Band 3 may add venepuncture, ECGs, discharge planning and mentoring juniors.

Hook: claim only skills you hold.

18 · Great Western Hospitals

Senior HCSW, Band 3

Respond constructively to change, share sensitive news well, role model for assistants.

Hook: a change you helped others through.

19 · Portsmouth Hospitals

HCSW, Band 2 or 3

Band set by experience and interview performance.

Hook: evidence both band specs.

20 · Epsom and St Helier

HCSW Band 3, medical ward

Care delegated and supervised by a registered nurse.

Hook: show when you escalated.

TRANSLATION KEY

Till work: calm with upset public.
Cleaning: infection control routines.
Kitchen: food hygiene and nutrition.

DOSSIER · NHS ADMIN · ADVERTS 21 TO 26

Band 4 medical secretaries: accuracy, discretion, systems

21 · University Hospitals Birmingham

Medical Secretary Supervisor

NVQ 3 or equivalent, terminology, over five years as a medical secretary, supervising others.

Hook: years, team size, outputs.

22 · University Hospitals Birmingham

Medical Secretary, hands

Audio typing clinic letters, discharge summaries and complaint replies; empathic contact for patients.

Hook: volume and accuracy figures.

23 · North Cumbria Integrated Care

Medical Secretary, Carlisle

Theatre lists, cancer pathway tracking, waiting time pathways; evidence every essential criterion.

Hook: name the systems you used.

24 · Tees, Esk and Wear Valleys

Senior Administrator, 6 months

Digital audio typing, diary management, minutes; may close early.

Hook: have a template ready to adapt.

25 · Dorset HealthCare

Medical Secretary, psychiatry

May handle distressing information; AI may enhance but not write the whole statement.

Hook: draft yourself, polish with AI.

26 · Hertfordshire Partnership

Senior Team Administrator

Care plan reviews, safeguarding meeting admin, minutes, medical terminology.

Hook: a minute taking example.

ADMIN PROOF = NUMBERS

Letters a week, turnaround time, diaries managed, error rates, backlog cleared.

Advert 25 in one line: write your rough draft first, then use the prompt on slide 59 only to tidy it.

WHAT NHS SUPPORT ROLES REWARD

The translation table: your past jobs in NHS language

What you did	What it proves	Criterion it can meet
Stadium or shop till	Calm, polite service under pressure and queues	Communication; customer care
Cleaning contract	Following hygiene routines and checklists exactly	Infection prevention awareness
Hospital kitchen	Food safety, allergens, mealtimes on wards	Nutrition and hydration support
Caring for a relative	Personal care, dignity, spotting changes	Compassion; observation and escalation
Warehouse or delivery	Shift work, reliability, safe manual handling	Flexibility; health and safety
Office reception	Diaries, confidentiality, phone etiquette	Admin accuracy; data protection

Prompt line: “I am new to care. Map each of my past jobs to the criteria using a table like this before you write anything.”

Honesty edge: a till job proves calm communication; it does not prove clinical skill. Keep the claim the right size.

Translate first, then write, then prove you will learn

Adverts 14 to 26

<role> You are an NHS recruiting manager for [healthcare support worker / medical secretary] posts who regularly hires people from outside healthcare. </role>
<job_pack> [advert, job description, person specification] </job_pack>
<my_history> [each job with dates and real examples; caring at home; volunteering; any certificates such as food hygiene or the Care Certificate] </my_history>
<my_draft> [optional: your own rough draft, in your words] </my_draft>
Step 1. Build a table mapping each essential criterion to the best experience in <my_history>, rated strong, partial or none. Stop and show me the table.
Step 2. When I reply "go", write my supporting information. If <my_draft> exists, improve it while keeping my words and examples; do not replace it. Explain transferable skills honestly: show what the experience proves, not more. Include a short paragraph showing how quickly I learn new procedures, with evidence.
<rules> British English · first person · no clinical skills I do not have · no patient or customer names · plain paragraphs · under [limit] · list any [GAP] at the end </rules>

NHS SUPPORT PROMPT · X RAY

Why this prompt stops halfway and waits for you

The approval gate

“Stop and show me the table” lets you correct a wrong mapping before it becomes 600 polished words built on sand.

Your draft is protected

“Improve it, do not replace it” keeps the statement yours, which is exactly what Dorset HealthCare’s AI notice asks for.

Right sized claims

“What the experience proves, not more” stops a cleaning job turning into “clinical infection control expertise”.

The learning paragraph

Barts tells newcomers they will complete Band 3 competencies within six months. Show the panel you can.

SWAP IN FOR MEDICAL SECRETARY POSTS

“Give each admin example a number: letters typed per week, turnaround time, diaries managed or errors reduced. Name every system I have used, such as patient administration systems, Microsoft Office or audio typing software, exactly as written in my history.”

SECTOR 3

The Civil Service

Ministry of Justice, Government Office for Science, DWP and HMRC: from Administrative Officer to data scientist. The most rule bound application system in Britain, and the most predictable once you know the rules.

Framework: Success Profiles, five elements

Statements: 250, 500 or 750 words

Often first: an online judgement or verbal test

14

adverts studied

DOSSIER · CIVIL SERVICE · ADVERTS 27 TO 33

Data roles and Work Coaches: precise limits, named behaviours

27 · Ministry of Justice

Data Scientist, HEO

CV and statement up to 750 words, both anonymised; Success Profiles plus the digital and data framework.

Hook: anonymity block, criteria order.

28 · Ministry of Justice

Data Scientist (Python), HEO

750 words with examples matched to the spec; data work in code or SQL.

Hook: tools plus outcomes.

29 · Government Office for Science

Data Scientist, HEO

Data ethics, version control, peer review; reserved for badged analytical professions.

Hook: check eligibility first.

30 · DWP

Bilingual Work Coach

One behaviour in 250 words: Communicating and Influencing, Level 2. Salary £32,137.

Hook: one flawless STAR story.

31 · DWP

Bilingual Work Coach, later round

Personal statement up to 250 words; behaviours, strengths and experience assessed.

Hook: CAR frame to save words.

32 · DWP, Galashiels

Universal Credit Work Coach

Judgement test first; then a 500 word statement against key criteria.

Hook: practise the test, then write.

33 · DWP, Wales and Marches

Universal Credit Work Coach

Up to 500 words on Managing a Quality Service at Executive Officer level.

Hook: paste the EO descriptors.

LEVEL FOLLOWS GRADE

Behaviours are written per grade. A Work Coach is an EO, so evidence at that level, not higher or lower.

DWP and HMRC operations: tests first, statement second

34 · DWP, South England

Universal Credit Work Coach

500 words on Managing a Quality Service; outer London salary £35,615.

Hook: customer focus with numbers.

35 · DWP, North West

Work Coach Team Leader

Lead 12 to 15 Work Coaches; reserve list held for up to 12 months.

Hook: team size and results.

36 · HMRC, Glasgow

Payments Officer, backshift

500 words: working with others, suitability, what you bring. Salary £28,016.

Hook: three labelled parts.

37 · HMRC, Glasgow

Payments Administrative Officer

Verbal test, then 500 words citing the spec and the Working Together behaviour.

Hook: name the behaviour.

38 · HMRC

Core Services Hub Officer

750 words of evidence against the job description and essential criteria.

Hook: criteria as labels.

39 · HMRC, multi site

Surge and Rapid Response AO

Customer service skills test and verbal test; Managing a Quality Service.

Hook: practise tests with AI.

40 · HMRC, Worthing

Payments Administrative Officer

500 words; with high volumes an initial sift may use the statement alone.

Hook: it must stand alone.

Reserve lists: a strong score can win a later vacancy even if you miss this one. Every statement is an investment.

WHAT THE CIVIL SERVICE REWARDS

Success Profiles: five elements, nine behaviours, one grade level

THE FIVE ELEMENTS

- **Behaviours** · what you have done
- **Strengths** · what energises you
- **Ability** · tests of aptitude
- **Experience** · CV and statement
- **Technical** · specialist skills

THE NINE BEHAVIOURS

Seeing the Big Picture	Changing and Improving	Making Effective Decisions
Leadership	Communicating and Influencing	Working Together
Developing Self and Others	**Managing a Quality Service**	Delivering at Pace

Recruiters pick only a few behaviours per vacancy, at the level for that grade. Generic “I am a team player” claims, as one department’s guidance puts it, tell the panel nothing.

PROMPT · CIVIL SERVICE BEHAVIOUR EXAMPLE

One behaviour, one grade, one story, every word counted

Adverts 30 to 39

<behaviour> [e.g. Managing a Quality Service] </behaviour> <grade> [e.g. Executive Officer, Level 2] </grade>

<descriptors> [paste the bullet points for this behaviour at this level from the official Success Profiles behaviours document] </descriptors>

<candidate_stories> [two or three stories from your evidence bank] </candidate_stories>

You are an experienced Civil Service sift assessor. First, inside <choice>, pick the one story that shows the most descriptors at this level, and say why in two sentences. Then write a [250 / 500] word example in STAR form:

· Situation and Task together: no more than 20% of the words.

· Action: at least 60%, as "I" statements, showing at least three descriptors in action without copying their wording.

· Result: at least 15%, with a number or concrete outcome, and the effect on customers or the service.

<rules> No facts outside <candidate_stories>. British English. Plain text. Never exceed the limit. </rules>

Finish with <checks>: the word count, which descriptors are evidenced and by which sentence, and any sentence that still says "we".

BEHAVIOUR PROMPT · X RAY

The word budget is the secret weapon

1. **Official descriptors pasted.** The AI writes to the real marking standard for your grade, not a guess.
2. **A choice before writing.** Picking from two or three stories finds the richest evidence.
3. **Percentages, not hopes.** Most weak statements spend half their words setting the scene.
4. **No copied wording.** Assessors notice descriptors pasted back at them; actions must show them.
5. **The "we" hunt.** Each leftover "we" hides you from the marker.

250 WORDS, BUDGETED



S and T	Action	Result
50	about 150	50

Reuse it: the same story, rewritten at 500 words, covers the longer DWP and HMRC boxes too.

PROMPT · CIVIL SERVICE PERSONAL STATEMENT

The 500 or 750 word statement against a person specification

Adverts 27, 28, 36 to 40

<advert> [full Civil Service Jobs advert, including “Things you need to know” and the exact statement instruction] </advert>
<essential_criteria> [paste] </essential_criteria>
<my_evidence> [paste] </my_evidence>

You are a Civil Service sift panel member. Quote back the exact statement instruction from <advert> so we both agree what is being asked. Then write a [500 / 750] word statement that follows it precisely:

· two sentences linking my motivation to this department’s purpose
· one paragraph per essential criterion, in order, each opening with the criterion in a few words, each built on one example with a result
· if the advert names a behaviour, such as Working Together, make sure at least one example clearly shows it
· a one sentence close on what I would bring

If the advert says the application is anonymised, remove my name, employers and institutions. Report the word count and any [GAP].

Why quote the instruction? HMRC adverts differ: one wants working with others, another the Working Together behaviour, another the essential criteria. Quoting first locks the target.

For technical roles such as advert 28, add: “name the tools I used, such as Python or SQL, and what each analysis changed.”

CIVIL SERVICE · BEFORE THE STATEMENT

Many adverts test you first. Practise with the AI as your coach.

PROMPT · JUDGEMENT TEST PRACTICE

I am preparing for a Civil Service Judgement Test for an [Administrative Officer / Executive Officer] role. Explain in plain English what this kind of test measures and how it links to the Civil Service Code values of integrity, honesty, objectivity and impartiality. Then give me five practice workplace scenarios, one at a time. For each, offer four possible responses. Wait for me to rank them from most to least effective, then explain the reasoning behind a sensible ranking. Remind me that real tests may differ from your practice items.

TESTS SEEN IN THE ADVERTS

Judgement test at Galashiels · verbal test at HMRC Glasgow · customer service skills and verbal tests for Surge and Rapid Response

THE HONEST LINE

Practise with AI, but take the real test alone. The point is to learn the reasoning, not to outsource it.

Strengths are usually tested at interview with quick questions about what energises you. Prepare with the prompt on slide 139.

SECTOR 4

Prisons, police and fire

HMPPS prison officers, police staff and promotion boards, firefighters and fire service support staff. Values first, then evidence, then tests and assessment days.

Police: the Competency and Values Framework

Prisons: behaviours, strengths and abilities

Fire: staged process, no CVs

11

adverts studied

Character and judgement, proven in tight word boxes

41 · HMPPS

Prison Officer, male prisons

No qualifications needed; online judgement and numeracy tests; assessment centre; may be offered a support grade.

Hook: values stories ready.

42 · HMPPS

Prison Officer, women's prisons

Scenario questions on the realities of women's custody, where many have experienced abuse.

Hook: calm, respectful motivation.

43 · HMPPS

Prison Officer Returners

Former officers who left within five years; questions on the role and why you want to return.

Hook: what you bring back.

44 · Durham Constabulary

External promotion

Personal statement evidenced against the CVF at level 2 or 3; weak evidence not shortlisted.

Hook: paste the level descriptors.

45 · South Yorkshire Police

Inspector promotion, 2026

Five questions: Courage, Emotionally Aware, We Collaborate, We Analyse Critically, Public Service.

Hook: one fresh story each.

46 · Police Scotland

Police staff posts

Evidence against advertised competencies, 150 words maximum each.

Hook: CAR, ruthlessly trimmed.

47 · Devon, Cornwall and Dorset

Police staff roles

Form and interview against the CVF; be concise; use STAR; the application must be your own work.

Hook: AI as coach only.

TRUTH CHECK

Police forms warn that false statements can lead to misconduct proceedings. Vetting will test what you write.

Firefighters: a staged marathon, and the statement opens it

48 · Royal Berkshire FRS

Wholetime Firefighter apprentice

Supporting statement guidance issued; CVs refused; £31,539 to £40,358; group exercise, physical tests, interview.

Hook: community safety motivation.

49 · Merseyside FRS

Wholetime Firefighter

Online form, then assessment days in June and July 2026, training from November 2026.

Hook: plan the calendar now.

50 · Oxfordshire FRS

Wholetime Firefighter

Eligibility questions, behavioural questionnaire, physical tests at Didcot.

Hook: answer eligibility honestly.

51 · Leicestershire FRS

Support staff posts

Answer the essential criteria flagged in the person spec; values and behaviours framework.

Hook: criteria in listed order.

THE POLICING CVF IN ONE BOX

Values: integrity, impartiality, public service, transparency.

Six competencies in three clusters: we are emotionally aware; we take ownership; we are collaborative; we deliver, support and inspire; we analyse critically; we are innovative and open minded.

Forces may add local values, as South Yorkshire did with Courage. Always paste the force's own list.

WHAT THESE SERVICES REWARD

Uniformed services test who you are under pressure

Values in action

Fairness when it was inconvenient. Honesty when it cost you. Respect for someone who was rude to you.

Calm under pressure

Calming tense situations is the everyday skill. Door staff, retail, hospitality and care all supply real stories.

Community focus

Firefighting is prevention as much as response: safety visits, schools, vulnerable residents.

Vetting reality

DBS and vetting checks follow. Anything you write may be tested against records and referees.

Level matters for police promotion. Durham asks for evidence at CVF level 2 or 3. A sergeant level story will not carry an inspector application.

Level check: ask the AI to tag each example with the CVF level it demonstrates, and to flag any that sit below the level you are applying for.

PROMPT · POLICE COMPETENCY AND VALUES ANSWERS

One question, one story, the right level, every time

Adverts 44 to 47

<framework> [paste the competencies and values named on the form, with the descriptors for the level required] </framework>

<questions> [paste every application question exactly as written] </questions> <limit> [150 / 250 / 400] words each </limit>

<my_stories> [your evidence bank; for promotions, recent examples from the last two years] </my_stories>

You are a police recruitment assessor who marks applications against the Competency and Values Framework.

Step 1. Build an allocation table: each question, the best story for it, and the CVF level that story shows. Use a different story for each question wherever possible. Show me the table and wait.

Step 2. After I approve, write each answer in STAR form within the limit. Show the specific behaviours of the competency through my actions. Close each answer with the effect on the public, victims or colleagues.

<rules> Nothing exaggerated or invented; this application may be checked during vetting. “I” not “we”. Plain British English. No jargon the public would not understand unless the question uses it. </rules>

End with a check table: question, story, level shown, word count, and any answer that sits below the level required.

POLICE PROMPT · X RAY

The allocation table stops you telling the same story five times

EXAMPLE ALLOCATION, SOUTH YORKSHIRE STYLE

Question	Story	Level
Courage	Challenged a colleague's remark	2
Emotionally Aware	Supported an officer after a call	2
We Collaborate	Joint patrol plan with housing team	3
Analyse Critically	Spotted a pattern in burglary data	3
Public Service	Ward meeting after a local incident	2

Illustrative only. Your table will use your own stories.

Exact questions pasted. Forms word competencies in their own way; answers must match.

Level column. Promotion boards reject evidence pitched at the rank you already hold.

Public impact close. Public Service is a CVF value; finishing on the public keeps it visible.

Vetting rule. Writing "may be checked during vetting" into the prompt quietly raises the honesty bar.

Motivation you can defend, and scenarios you have rehearsed

PROMPT A · FIREFIGHTER STATEMENT

<guidance> [paste the service's supporting statement guidance and job profile] </guidance>
<me> [your work, volunteering, sport, community involvement, and the real reason you want this job] </me>
Act as a fire and rescue recruitment officer. Answer each point in <guidance> in order, using my real examples. Show that I understand firefighting includes prevention, safety advice and work with diverse and vulnerable communities, not only emergencies. Keep my motivation personal and specific, never heroic clichés. British English, within [limit]. List any guidance point I have not evidenced.

PROMPT B · PRISON SCENARIO REHEARSAL

I am applying to be a prison officer in a [women's / men's] prison. Act as an HMPPS assessor. Give me one realistic scenario at a time, of the kind an officer might face on a wing, such as a distressed resident or a disagreement between colleagues. Wait for my answer. Then tell me what a strong answer shows: safety, respect, fairness, calm communication, and awareness that many people in custody have experienced trauma. Score my answer from 1 to 5 and suggest one improvement. Five scenarios, then a summary of my patterns.

Why rehearse: HMPPS adverts say questions explore your understanding of the role and your motivation through situations you may face. Practising aloud builds the instinct; the AI cannot sit the assessment for you.

SECTOR 5

Local councils

Manchester, Brighton and Hove, Fife, Birmingham, Stockport, Coventry and Kent: customer service, business support, highways, housing and social work.

The rule: no statement, no shortlist

The trap: a CV pasted as a statement

The edge: local knowledge and council values

14

adverts studied

Manchester and Brighton: small instructions, big consequences

52 · Manchester City Council

Customer Service Centre Advisor

750 to 1000 words on set areas plus essentials; say full or part time.

Hook: tick off every listed area.

53 · Manchester City Council

Business Support Officer

Confident with residents in person and by phone; proof of Manchester residency.

Hook: check residency first.

54 · Manchester City Council

CATEC Support Officer

If you finished the GM Elevate leadership programme, say so in the statement.

Hook: never miss a stated ask.

55 · Manchester City Council

Administrative Officer, Grade 4

£26,403 to £28,142, Town Hall Extension; Our Manchester behaviours.

Hook: weave behaviours into stories.

56 · Manchester City Council

Business Support Officer L1

Residency for grades 1 to 3; knowledge of council finance, HR or case systems.

Hook: name systems you know.

57 · Manchester City Council

Highways Technical Officer

Assess roadworks under the Greater Manchester Road Activity Permit Scheme.

Hook: technical plus public impact.

58 · Brighton and Hove

Rehousing Officer, fixed term

The supporting statement is the most important part and decides the shortlist.

Hook: treat it as the application.

OUR MANCHESTER

Behaviours quoted in the adverts: work together and trust each other; value differences and treat people fairly; proud and passionate about Manchester.

Housing and social work: casework stories with real outcomes

59 · Fife Council

Housing Management Officer

Statement mandatory and must not be a CV; review the role profile first.

Hook: paste the role profile.

60 · Fife Council

Housing Options Officer

Needs assessments, Personal Housing Plans, case management throughout.

Hook: one full case journey.

61 · Birmingham City Council

Localities Housing Officer

Internal post; statement up to 1500 words; 59,000 council homes.

Hook: depth for every criterion.

62 · Birmingham City Council

Housing Officer

Statement uploaded as an attachment; without it, no consideration.

Hook: check the upload worked.

63 · Stockport Council

Experienced Social Worker

Welcomes AI as a tool, wants authenticity; Social Work England registration.

Hook: your reflective voice.

64 · Coventry City Council

Adult Social Worker

Care Act 2014, Mental Capacity Act 2005, personalisation, strong assessment.

Hook: law applied in a real case.

65 · Kent County Council

Social Worker, disabilities

Caseload aimed at independent living; enhanced DBS; registration required.

Hook: outcomes for independence.

Three councils, one message: Fife, Birmingham and Brighton all say the statement decides whether you progress.

WHAT COUNCILS REWARD

Statement, not CV: the difference in one picture

A CV IN DISGUISE · FAILS

2022 to 2025, Customer Assistant, national retailer. Duties: serving customers, handling complaints, cash handling, stock rotation. 2019 to 2022, Receptionist. Duties: answering phones, booking appointments.

Lists duties. Proves nothing. Matches no criterion.

A REAL STATEMENT · SCORES

DEALING WITH DIFFICULT ENQUIRIES. When a customer arrived upset about a refund refused twice, I listened without interrupting, checked the policy, found an error, and arranged the refund the same day. She later thanked our manager by email.

Names the criterion. Shows behaviour. Gives a result.

Local edge: councils serve places. A line on why you care about this borough, backed by a real connection, adds weight.

Small asks: full or part time, GM Elevate, residency, a location preference. Missed asks look careless.

PROMPT · COUNCIL SUPPORTING STATEMENT

Every criterion, every small ask, every council value

Adverts 52 to 62

<advert> [full advert, including every line about how to apply] </advert>
<role_profile> [job description and person specification or role profile] </role_profile>
<council_values> [the council's values or behaviours, quoted from the advert or careers site] </council_values>
<my_evidence> [evidence bank, plus any real link to this area] </my_evidence>
You are a council HR shortlister. **First**, list every instruction in <advert> about the statement: length, topics to cover, things to declare such as full or part time, leadership programmes, residency or location preference. **Second**, write my supporting statement, not a CV: a short opening on why this council and this service, then each essential criterion in order with a real example and result, showing the council values through actions. Include every declaration from your list. **Third**, a short close.

<rules> First person · British English · only my facts, [GAP] otherwise · within [limit] · no job duty lists </rules>
End with a checklist confirming each advert instruction was met, and the word count.

COUNCIL PROMPT · X RAY

The extraction step catches the marks most people drop

1. **“First, list every instruction.”** Forces the AI to find the full or part time line, the GM Elevate line and the location preference before writing.
2. **“Not a CV.”** Fife says it outright. The phrase blocks the duty list habit.
3. **Values through actions.** “I treated each caller fairly by…” beats “I share the value of fairness”.
4. **A real local link.** Only if true: you live here, use the service, volunteer locally.

GROK ADD ON · COUNCIL RESEARCH

Search for [council name]’s current corporate plan and recent news about [service]. Give me three priorities in plain English, each with a source, and suggest which of my examples connects to each. Do not write my statement.

Verify the sources it gives before you mention any priority. A wrong fact about the council is worse than none.

PROMPT · SOCIAL WORKER STATEMENT

Reflective, lawful, person centred, and unmistakably yours

Adverts 63 to 65

<job_pack> [advert and person specification] </job_pack>
<my_reflections> [your own rough notes on two or three anonymised cases: what happened, what you did, which law or framework guided you, what you learned in supervision] </my_reflections>
<my_registration> [registration status and post qualifying training] </my_registration>

You are a team manager in [adults / children's] social care who shortlists social workers. Using <my_reflections> as the core, write my statement against the person specification. Keep my own phrases wherever they are clear; this council values authenticity.

For each case use STARR. Name the legislation or framework only where my notes show I applied it, such as the Care Act 2014 or the Mental Capacity Act 2005, and show how it shaped a decision. Keep the person's voice and outcomes at the centre. Anonymise completely.

Within [limit]. Afterwards, list any criterion my reflections do not cover and one question to help me find an example.

Why your notes lead: Stockport's advert asks for authenticity. Starting from your reflections, not a blank page, keeps the voice yours.

Law in practice: Coventry names the Care Act and Mental Capacity Act. Showing them used in a decision beats listing them.

SECTOR 6

Museums, heritage and libraries

Small teams, big standards. Councils from Leicestershire to Bridgwater want collections expertise, volunteer leadership and a talent for bringing people through the door.

Formats vary: form only, or CV plus statement

Standards: SPECTRUM, Museum Accreditation

People: visitors, volunteers, artists

6

adverts studied

DOSSIER · CULTURE · ADVERTS 66 TO 71

Collections care meets community engagement

66 · Leicestershire County Council

Museum Volunteering Officer

Upload a statement on the "About You" criteria: guiding volunteers, health and safety, public contact.

Hook: volunteer leadership stories.

67 · Chesterfield Borough Council

Museum Collections Officer

No CVs, form only; postgraduate museum qualification; SPECTRUM and Accreditation.

Hook: answer the form's boxes.

68 · Erewash Borough Council

Heritage and Collections Officer

CV plus a supporting statement; collections management experience essential.

Hook: statement adds the why.

69 · Rutland County Council

Museum Officer, collections

Rutland Museum and Oakham Castle; contributes to a small dedicated team.

Hook: teamwork in tiny teams.

70 · St Helens Borough Council

Creative Programme Officer

Arts in Libraries, an Arts Council National Portfolio service; artist development.

Hook: events you delivered.

71 · Bridgwater Town Council

Museum and Heritage Officer

Blake Museum; £29,064 to £31,022; information pack and form.

Hook: exhibitions and learning.

SECTOR LANGUAGE

Documentation, object handling, audience development, outreach, learning programmes, accessibility.

Form only? Paste each box's question into the prompt separately, with its own limit.

Box by box for forms, criterion by criterion for statements

Adverts 66 to 71

<format> [Choose one: “application form with these boxes: box name, question, limit…” OR “CV plus supporting statement”] </format>
<job_pack> [advert, job description, person specification] </job_pack>
<my_heritage_evidence> [collections work, documentation systems, exhibitions, events, volunteers led, visitor numbers, learning sessions, funding bids, qualifications] </my_heritage_evidence>

You are a museum manager recruiting for a small local authority service. If <format> is a form, write a separate answer for each box, within its limit, that directly answers its question. If it is a statement, address each criterion in order. In both cases use correct sector terms only where my evidence supports them, such as documentation standards, object handling, audience development and accessible interpretation. Give numbers: objects catalogued, visitors, volunteers, events. Show how my work helped people enjoy and learn from collections. British English. Mark gaps as [GAP].

The switch line makes one prompt handle Chesterfield’s form only process and Erewash’s CV plus statement.

Do not bluff standards. If you have never used a collections database, say what you have used and how you learn systems.

Volunteers count: volunteering at a museum is genuine sector experience. Include it.

SECTOR 7

Universities

Lecturers at Worcester and Lancaster, researchers and administrators at Manchester and Manchester Metropolitan. Academic statements are scored line by line, and they ask the question most applicants dodge: why here?

Each criterion says where it is assessed

Research fit with the department

Admin roles: examples for every line

15

adverts studied

Lecturers: scored statements and the “why us” question

72 · University of Worcester

Lecturer, Business and HR

Each criterion tagged: application form, supporting statement or interview.

Hook: answer statement rows only.

73 · University of Worcester

Lecturer, Psychology

Postgraduate degree with professional registration route; HE teaching evidence.

Hook: teaching with outcomes.

74 · University of Worcester

Lecturer, FE and Skills

QTS or QTLS; observing trainee teachers and giving quality feedback.

Hook: a feedback story.

75 · University of Worcester

Lecturer, English Language

PhD or clear potential; convening modules; course administration.

Hook: modules you led.

76 · Lancaster University

Lecturer, Sociolinguistics

State your rationale for Lancaster and how your research fits the department’s plans.

Hook: name colleagues and centres.

77 · Lancaster University

Lecturer, Social Statistics

Statements are scored at shortlisting; experience with health data access desirable.

Hook: methods with examples.

78 · Lancaster University

Lecturer, International Strategy

Research complementary to the department; top journals and funding potential desirable.

Hook: pipeline, not just record.

79 · Lancaster University

Lecturer, Pharmacology

Rationale for this post and fit with the Medical School; flexible teaching.

Hook: teaching philosophy, briefly.

Researchers and administrators: examples for every line

80 · University of Manchester

Research Associate, ML

Two posts; PhD or near; probabilistic modelling and inference.

Hook: papers, code, methods.

81 · University of Manchester

Lecturer, Foundation Studies

Curriculum review and new courses, including AI materials; £37,694 to £46,049.

Hook: course design evidence.

82 · University of Manchester

Operations Admin Assistant

Use “additional information” for examples against each essential and desirable criterion.

Hook: that box is your statement.

83 · University of Manchester

PGR Administrator

Doctoral Academy support; the person spec sits in the further particulars.

Hook: open the further particulars.

84 · University of Manchester

Division Administrator

GCSE Maths and English; systems such as Oracle and iProc; first point of contact.

Hook: name systems honestly.

85 · Manchester Metropolitan

PGR Support Administrator

Statement with examples matching each person spec requirement.

Hook: one example per line.

86 · Manchester Metropolitan

Education Services Admin

Placements team; attention to detail and excellent customer service.

Hook: accuracy under deadline.

HIDDEN DOCUMENT

University adverts often put the person spec in “further particulars”. Download it before prompting.

WHAT UNIVERSITIES REWARD

Four rooms of an academic statement, and the filter at the door

Research

Record, current work, pipeline, funding, fit with groups.

Teaching

Modules, methods, assessment, feedback, student outcomes.

Citizenship

Admin roles, pastoral care, outreach, inclusion work.

Why here

Named themes, programmes and colleagues that fit you.

THE FILTER AT THE DOOR

Worcester and Lancaster tag each criterion with where it is assessed. Criteria marked “supporting statement” need written evidence; those marked “interview” do not belong in your word budget.

The “why here” test: if you could swap the university’s name for another and the paragraph still works, it is not specific enough.

PROMPT · ACADEMIC SUPPORTING STATEMENT

Built for lecturers and researchers, best run in Opus 5.5

Adverts 72 to 81

<person_spec> [every criterion with essential or desirable and where it is assessed] </person_spec>
<department> [from its website: research groups, themes, programmes, recent strategy] </department>
<my_record> [academic CV: degrees, publications, grants, modules, feedback, supervision, roles] </my_record> <plans> [next three to five years] </plans>
You are a head of department on this appointment panel. Address only criteria assessed by supporting statement, in their listed order, grouped under Research, Teaching, Citizenship and Why this department. In “Why this department”, connect my work to two or three specific items from <department>, explaining what I would add, not just admire. In Teaching, show methods, assessment and student outcomes. In Research, show trajectory: past, present, next.
<rules> 1. Never invent a publication, grant, score, student number or colleague. 2. Cite only items in <my_record>. 3. Confident, precise, British academic register; no hype words. 4. Within [limit or pages]. </rules>
Finish with a table: criterion, where assessed, section that addresses it, evidence strength. Flag any statement criterion left unaddressed.

ACADEMIC PROMPT · X RAY

“What I would add, not just admire”

1. **Statement rows only.** Saves words for what the panel will actually score at shortlisting.
2. **Department pack pasted.** Lancaster asks how your research fits its plans; the AI cannot answer without them.
3. **Contribution framing.** Panels hire colleagues who strengthen groups, not fans of them.
4. **Rule 1 is career critical.** An invented citation in an academic application is a serious integrity issue.

Admire: “I am impressed by your excellent research in language variation.”

Add: “My corpus of northern English speech would extend the department’s work on variation and supports a final year module I could lead.”

Grok helper: “Search this department’s recent news and list its research groups with links.” Then paste the verified results into <department>.

PROMPT · UNIVERSITY PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

The “additional information” box, done properly

PROMPT · CRITERION LABELLED EVIDENCE

<further_particulars> [paste the full person specification, keeping any numbering] </further_particulars>
<my_evidence> [paste] </my_evidence>
You are a university professional services manager shortlisting administrators. For each essential criterion, then each desirable one, write a label using the criterion’s number or a short title, then one compact paragraph with a specific example: what I handled, which system or process, how much or how many, and the result. Name systems exactly as in my evidence; if the criterion names a system I have not used, say what similar system I used and how quickly I learned it. Keep student and staff details anonymous. Plain text for a web form. Within [limit].

Why labels? Manchester’s adverts ask for examples against each criterion. Labels let the panel tick each one fast.

The system clause handles Oracle and iProc style criteria honestly, turning a gap into proof of adaptability.

Bonus: the same output doubles as your interview prep sheet.

SECTOR 8

Schools and further education

Teaching assistants, learning support and apprentices in schools; lecturers in engineering, business and computing at Greater Manchester colleges. Safeguarding runs through every one.

Always: a clear commitment to safeguarding

Often: a direct question about motivation

For FE: industry experience turned teacher

6

adverts studied

Children first, subject second, safeguarding always

87 · Primary school

Teaching Assistant L1, KS2

Two posts via Teaching Vacancies; recruitment pack with supporting information; firm safeguarding commitment.

Hook: read the whole pack.

88 · Barnwood Park School

Teaching Assistant Apprentice

SEND team; Level 3 apprenticeship; asks what attracted you to the role.

Hook: honest, specific motivation.

89 · North Yorkshire school

Learning Support Assistant

Short contract; literacy, numeracy, experience with additional learning needs; enhanced DBS.

Hook: one pupil progress story.

90 · College near Wigan

Engineering Lecturer

£45,119; awarding body assessment; early career FE teachers may qualify for an extra premium.

Hook: industry to classroom.

91 · Greater Manchester college

Business Lecturer

BTEC and T Level Business; recognised teaching qualification; DBS on the update service.

Hook: qualification and DBS first.

92 · Greater Manchester college

Computer Science Lecturer

T Level delivery experience essential; full time cover; DBS on the update service.

Hook: T Level evidence up front.

SAFEGUARDING LINE

Schools work to statutory guidance, Keeping Children Safe in Education. Show you know to report concerns.

Agency roles: 90 to 92 came via recruiters. Send a tight profile, then the college's form.

Warm, safe, specific: the school support statement

Adverts 87 to 89

<school_pack> [advert, job description, person specification, and any questions on the form, such as “What attracted you to this role?”] </school_pack>

<my_experience> [work with children: paid, volunteering, clubs, faith groups, parenting; qualifications; training such as safeguarding or first aid; anything with special educational needs] </my_experience>

You are a headteacher shortlisting support staff. Write my personal statement for this school.

1. If the form asks a direct question, answer it first and specifically, mentioning something real about this school from <school_pack>.
2. Then address the person specification in order with short, concrete examples involving children: helping a pupil read, calming a worried child, adapting an activity.
3. Include one clear paragraph on safeguarding: that I understand my duty to report concerns promptly through the school’s procedures, and any training I hold.
4. Show how I support the teacher, not replace them.

<rules> Never name or identify a child. Parenting experience counts but keep the claim the right size. British English, warm but professional, within [limit]. List any [GAP]. </rules>

PROMPT · FE LECTURER, FROM INDUSTRY TO CLASSROOM

Turn years on the job into credibility in front of 16 year olds

PROMPT · TWO OUTPUTS IN ONE

<role> [advert and job description] </role>
<me> [industry career, projects, apprentices or juniors trained, any teaching, assessing or mentoring, teaching qualification status, DBS status] </me>
You are a further education curriculum manager. Produce two things.
A. A 120 word profile I can send to the recruitment agency, leading with my subject, the qualifications I can teach, my teaching qualification and DBS status.
B. A supporting statement for the college that shows: real industry examples I can bring into lessons; how I have explained technical ideas to beginners; how I assess and track progress; my commitment to safeguarding young people; and my plan to gain or complete a teaching qualification if I do not hold one. Only use facts from <me>. British English. Within [limit].

Why two outputs? Adverts 90 to 92 ran through agencies. The profile wins the call; the statement wins the post.

Hard filters: T Level experience for advert 92, a teaching qualification for advert 91. Put them in the first lines.

Engineers and coders: your workplace stories are your teaching resources. Say so.

SECTORS 9 AND 10

Charities and transport

Homelessness and youth charities in London and Nottinghamshire, and Transport for Greater Manchester as the Bee Network grows. Mission and values sit at the centre of both.

Charities: lived experience can be evidence

TfGM: criteria questions answered with examples

Both: anonymised CVs on some roles

7

adverts studied

Mission led employers want proof you share the mission

93 · St Mungo's

Support Worker, Euston

£34,116 to £38,115; complex needs; lived experience welcomed; location preference in the statement.

Hook: change you supported.

94 · Single Homeless Project

Project Worker, Lewisham

Anonymised CV plus statement of your most relevant skills and knowledge.

Hook: anonymity block on.

95 · Children's charity

Youth Project Worker

Nottinghamshire, three months, £14.34 an hour; safeguarding; enhanced DBS.

Hook: fast start evidence.

96 · TfGM

Bee Network Operational Assistant

CV plus clear examples against the criteria questions; complete it personally.

Hook: one example per question.

97 · GMCA for TfGM

Graduate Planner

Supports the Local Transport Plan within the Bee Network vision.

Hook: degree projects as evidence.

98 · TfGM

Senior Revenue Accountant

Leads the Metrolink revenue budget; mention GM Elevate if completed.

Hook: budgets with figures.

99 · TfGM

Active Travel Network Officer

Strategic Cycle Network planning; GIS helpful but not essential.

Hook: say "helpful" honestly.

TFGM VALUES

Deliver, Care and Adapt. Give each criteria answer a natural link to one of the three.

PROMPT · CHARITY SUPPORT WORK

Strengths based, trauma aware, and honest about lived experience

PROMPT · CHARITY SUPPORTING STATEMENT

<charity> [advert, job description, and the charity's mission and values page] </charity>
<my_experience> [paid and voluntary work with people facing hardship; caseloads; key work; partner agencies; training such as safeguarding or mental health first aid] </my_experience>
<lived_experience> [optional: only what you are comfortable sharing, and how it shapes your practice] </lived_experience>
You are a service manager at this charity. Write my supporting statement against the criteria in order. Show how I build trust, focus on people's strengths, set boundaries, work with partner agencies, record accurately and safeguard. If <lived_experience> is given, use it briefly and with dignity, focusing on insight, not detail. Mirror the charity's values with real actions. Include any declarations the advert asks for, such as location preference. British English, within [limit]. Anonymise every client.

Why "optional": St Mungo's welcomes lived experience, but you decide how much to share. The prompt protects that choice.

Insight, not detail: one sentence on what it taught you outweighs a paragraph of history.

Anonymised CV roles such as advert 94: add the anonymity block from slide 27.

PROMPT · CRITERIA QUESTIONS ON AN ONLINE FORM

When the form asks questions instead of a statement

PROMPT · GROK FRIENDLY VERSION

I am applying to Transport for Greater Manchester for [role]. The form has these criteria questions, each with its own box: [paste each question and any limit]. Their values are Deliver, Care and Adapt. Here is my real experience: [paste].

For each question, write a separate answer that starts by answering the question directly in one sentence, then gives one specific example from my experience as situation, action and result, and ends with a short line linking to one of their values where it fits naturally. Keep each answer within its limit, plain British English, no jokes, no invented details.

After the answers, check: did any two answers use the same example? If so, suggest a swap from my experience.

"Complete it personally": TfGM asks applicants to complete the application themselves. Use these answers as drafts you rewrite in your own words.

Direct first sentence means a skim reader sees the answer before the story.

Duplicate check: repeating one story across boxes is the most common form mistake.

SECTOR 11

Private sector tech: AI and machine learning in Manchester

From junior AI engineer to senior MLOps. No person specification, no word limits: a CV, a short note and a portfolio do all the talking, often read first by a recruiter in under a minute.

Gate 1: keyword match

Gate 2: measurable impact

Gate 3: proof in code

5

adverts studied

DOSSIER · PRIVATE SECTOR TECH · ADVERTS 100 TO 104

Machine learning roles: production, not just prototypes

100 · Robert Walters client

ML Engineer, hybrid

£80,000 to £90,000; production ML and generative AI; model governance; TensorFlow, PyTorch, scikit learn.

Hook: deployment and governance.

101 · UrbanChain

ML Engineer or Data Scientist

Build and deploy models; data pipelines; Python and R; work with engineers.

Hook: pipeline projects.

102 · Gravitas client

Senior MLOps Engineer

£60,000 to £70,000 plus equity; three days on site; client deployments; runs sprint planning.

Hook: client facing delivery.

103 · ECOM client

Senior ML Engineer

£80,000; five years or more deploying models; leads the full lifecycle.

Hook: years must be real.

104 · Adria Solutions client

Junior AI Engineer

Two office days in Manchester; data cleaning, feature engineering, model evaluation.

Hook: portfolio over pedigree.

KEYWORDS ARE FILTERS

Recruiters search for named tools. Spell them as the advert does, but only list what you have used.

THE PACKAGE

Tailored CV, short cover note, recruiter message, and two strong repositories with clear READMEs.

Speed: agency roles fill fast. Have the prompts on the next two slides saved and ready.

WHAT PRIVATE TECH REWARDS

The bullet formula that survives a 30 second scan

VERB	WHAT	TOOLS	RESULT
Built, deployed, cut, automated	a fire detection model for CCTV	using PyTorch and Docker	reaching [your real metric]

Weak bullet: Responsible for machine learning models and working with data.

Strong bullet: Deployed a PyTorch image classifier as a Docker service, cutting manual review time by [real figure].

No metric? Use scale (rows, users, models), speed, or a before and after. Never invent a percentage.

Plain layout: applicant tracking systems can garble tables, columns and icons. One column, standard headings.

Governance matters: advert 100 names model governance. Show documentation and testing habits.

PROMPT · TECH CV TAILORING

Match the advert’s language without stretching the truth

Adverts 100 to 104

<job_ad> [full advert] </job_ad> <my_cv> [current CV text] </my_cv>

<projects> [short summaries or README text of your best repositories, with real results] </projects>

You are a UK technical hiring manager for machine learning roles who also knows how recruiters and applicant tracking systems screen CVs.

1. Table every required and desirable skill in <job_ad>, its exact spelling, and whether <my_cv> or <projects> proves it: yes, partly or no.
2. Rewrite my three line profile for this role.
3. Rewrite the bullets for my two most recent roles as verb, what, tools, result. Use the advert’s spelling of a tool only where I genuinely used it.
4. Choose the two projects that best match, and write two bullets each.
5. List skills marked “no”. Do not add them anywhere; suggest how I could honestly build each.

<rules> No invented metrics: where a result is missing, write [METRIC?] and ask me. British spelling. One column, standard headings, no tables or icons in the CV itself. Two pages maximum. </rules>

PROMPT · RECRUITER PACKAGE

Three short texts that get a recruiter to call you today

PROMPT · WORKS WELL IN GROK OR OPUS 5.5

Here is a job advert: [paste]. Here is my tailored CV: [paste]. My notice period is [x], my salary expectation is [range], and my right to work status is [state it accurately].

Write three things in plain, confident British English with no hype:

1. A cover note of up to 150 words for the application form: the role, my two strongest matching achievements with real results, and my availability.
2. A LinkedIn message to the recruiter of up to 60 words that names the role and one specific match, ending with a simple request for a short call.
3. A 30 second phone pitch as three short spoken sentences I can say when they ring.

Use only facts from my CV. Do not use words like "passionate", "rockstar" or "ninja".

Why state right to work? Several adverts in this study addressed sponsorship directly. Be accurate and clear; recruiters ask early.

The spoken pitch is the most skipped and most useful. Read it aloud twice before the phone rings.

Salary: giving a researched range keeps you in control. See slide 118.

PART FOUR

4

Letters, statements and every other application

From the first cover letter to the resignation letter, from UCAS to a PhD, from a small grant to a formal appeal. Each with a ready prompt and the reasoning behind it.

Job search letters · 107 to 115

Offers and exits · 116 to 122

Education · 123 to 125

Funding and volunteering · 126 to 128

Complaints and appeals · 129 to 130

Tone matrix · 131

ANATOMY OF A BRITISH FORMAL LETTER

Tell the AI the conventions, or it may use American ones

Your name · town · email · phone

22 October 2026

Ms A Patel, Recruitment Manager, [Organisation]

Dear Ms Patel,

Re: Customer Service Advisor, reference [number]

Opening paragraph: why you are writing, in one or two sentences.

Body: the evidence or the facts, one idea per paragraph.

Close: what you want to happen next, and by when.

Yours sincerely,

[Your name]

Sign off rule: “Yours sincerely” when you named the person; “Yours faithfully” after “Dear Sir or Madam”.

Dates: 22 October 2026, day first. Never 10/22/2026.

Subject line: “Re:” plus the role and any reference number.

Add to any letter prompt: “Follow British formal letter conventions, including date format and the correct sign off.”

PROMPT · COVER LETTER

Four paragraphs, 300 words, zero clichés

Any sector

<job_ad> [full advert] </job_ad> <my_cv> [paste] </my_cv>

<why_them> [one or two real, specific reasons: a product, a value, a project, a conversation you had] </why_them>

You are the hiring manager for this role. Write my cover letter in four paragraphs and no more than 300 words:

1. Hook: the role, plus one achievement from <my_cv> that matters most for this job.

2. Fit: the two most important requirements in <job_ad>, each matched with evidence and a result.

3. Why you: use <why_them> and connect it to what I would contribute.

4. Close: availability and a confident, polite request to discuss.

<rules> Do not open with “I am writing to apply”. No “passionate”, “dynamic”, “team player”. Only facts from my documents. British formal letter conventions with the correct sign off. Address it to [name] if known. </rules>

After the letter, give two alternative first sentences so I can choose the one that sounds most like me.

COVER LETTER PROMPT · X RAY

A letter shaped like a short argument

1

Hook

Claim: I am the right person, and here is the single best proof.

2

Fit

Evidence: their top two needs, met by my two best results.

3

Why you

Motive: a real reason only this employer fits.

4

Close

Action: a clear next step, politely asked for.

The banned opener. “I am writing to apply” wastes the most valuable line. The hook earns attention instead.

<why_them> is yours to supply. Without it, the AI writes flattery that fits any company.

Two alternative first lines. Choosing between options keeps your voice in charge.

PROMPT · GENERAL CV REBUILD

From a list of duties to a record of results, for any sector

PROMPT · CV REBUILD

<old_cv> [paste] </old_cv> <target> [the kind of role and sector you want next] </target>
You are a UK careers adviser. Rebuild my CV for <target>:
1. Contact line: name, town, phone, email, LinkedIn. No photo, date of birth or marital status.
2. A three line profile aimed at <target>.
3. Key skills: eight short items supported by my history.
4. Experience, newest first, three to five bullets per role, each starting with a strong verb and ending with a result.
5. Education and training, newest first.
Ask me questions where a result is missing rather than inventing one, and mark those bullets [ASK]. Two pages maximum, British spelling, plain one column layout.

UK norms: photos, ages and marital status are not expected on UK CVs and can invite bias. The prompt removes them.

[ASK] markers turn the CV into a conversation. Answer them and the bullets get sharper.

Then tailor: use the tech version on slide 104 or the decoder on slide 47 for each advert.

PROMPT · GAPS, CHANGES AND OVERSEAS EXPERIENCE

Explain the unusual parts of your story with calm confidence

PROMPT · THE BRIDGE PARAGRAPH

I need one short paragraph for my [statement / cover letter] explaining [a career gap / a change of sector / experience gained outside the UK / taking a lower level role while studying]. The facts are: [what happened, dates, what you did during that time, what you learned].

Write it in no more than 80 words. Be factual and brief about the reason, then spend most words on what I gained and why it makes me ready for this role. Do not apologise, over explain or share private details I have not listed. For overseas experience, describe employers and qualifications in terms a UK panel will recognise, such as size, sector and level, without inflating them.

Give me two versions: one neutral, one warmer.

Brief reason, long benefit. Panels care about readiness now, not the detail of then.

Privacy stays yours. You never have to disclose health or family details in a statement.

Overseas degrees: name the qualification accurately; if you have a UK comparability statement, mention it.

Two versions let you pick the tone that matches the employer.

PROMPT · LINKEDIN HEADLINE AND ABOUT

Be findable by the recruiters who filled these 104 jobs

PROMPT · PROFILE MAKEOVER

Here is my CV: [paste]. I want roles like: [two or three job titles]. Here are three adverts I would love to get: [paste or summarise].

1. Find the ten skills and terms that appear most across the adverts and that my CV genuinely supports.
2. Write five headline options under 220 characters, each with my target title, two key skills and a hint of the value I bring.
3. Write an About section of about 200 words in the first person: what I do, two achievements with results, what I am looking for next, and how to contact me. Weave the ten terms in naturally.
4. Suggest three short posts I could write from my real experience to show expertise.

Plain, confident British English. No buzzwords. Nothing I cannot back up.

Grok angle: it can look at public posts on X. Ask what topics hiring managers in your field discuss right now, then write posts on those.

Headline first. It shows in search results, so it does the most work.

Consistency check: titles and dates must match your CV exactly. Recruiters compare.

PROMPT · SPECULATIVE APPLICATION

Knock on a door that has no vacancy sign on it

PROMPT · SPECULATIVE EMAIL

I want to contact [organisation] about [type of role], although nothing is advertised. What I know about them: [two or three real facts]. My CV summary: [paste]. The person I am writing to: [name and role, if known].

Write an email of no more than 200 words with a clear subject line. Paragraph one: a specific reason I chose them. Paragraph two: two strengths with real evidence that match their work. Paragraph three: a modest request for a short conversation, or to be kept in mind for future roles, with my CV attached. British conventions and the right sign off.

Then write a three line follow up to send if there is no reply after two weeks.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

Modest ask. A 15 minute call is easy to say yes to; "give me a job" is not.

Research with Grok first: recent projects or news give you the "specific reason".

PROMPT · CHASING AN APPLICATION POLITELY

Silence after the closing date? Ask without pressure.

PROMPT · FOLLOW UP EMAIL

I applied for [role and reference number] at [organisation] on [date]. The closing date was [date] and the advert said [anything about shortlisting dates]. The contact named on the advert is [name and role].

Write a polite email of no more than 100 words with a subject line that includes the reference number. Ask when shortlisting decisions are expected. Restate my interest in one sentence, mentioning one strength relevant to the role. Do not sound impatient, apologetic or guilty. British conventions, correct sign off.

Also tell me whether, based on the advert details I gave, it is reasonable to send this now or better to wait.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

Check the advert first. Many public sector adverts state interview dates, and Civil Service Jobs updates your account directly.

The timing question stops you chasing a day after the deadline.

PROMPT · THANK YOU AFTER INTERVIEW

Sent within a day, specific to the conversation, short

PROMPT · THANK YOU EMAIL

I was interviewed today for [role] at [organisation] by [names and roles]. Things we discussed that stood out: [one or two specific topics]. One answer I felt I could have given better: [question and the stronger point I wish I had made].

Write a thank you email of no more than 150 words. Thank them for their time. Refer to one specific topic we discussed. Restate in one sentence why I fit the role. If it reads naturally, add one sentence that strengthens my weaker answer without sounding defensive. Close warmly and professionally. Subject line included.

Note: if this was a formal panel for a public sector role, tell me whether a short email is appropriate or whether a thank you at the end of the interview was enough.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

Sector sense: scored public panels may not weigh follow up emails; private employers often notice them.

One repair line only. Arguing the whole interview again reads as anxiety.

PROMPT · ACCEPTING AN OFFER

Say yes clearly, and confirm every detail in writing

PROMPT · ACCEPTANCE EMAIL

I have been offered [role] at [organisation]. Details from the offer: salary [exact figure or band point], hours [x], location [x], proposed start date [x], conditions [such as references, DBS, right to work checks, occupational health, qualifications]. My questions: [any, such as hybrid days or annual leave].

Write a warm, professional acceptance email of no more than 180 words. Accept the offer clearly. Restate the key details exactly as I gave them so there is a written record. Confirm I will complete the conditions promptly. Ask my questions politely. Ask when to expect the written contract. Use only the figures I provided.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

Do not resign yet if the offer is conditional. Wait until checks clear, unless you are comfortable with the risk.

Exact figures only. An AI "rounding" your salary in writing creates confusion later.

PROMPT · DECLINING AN OFFER

Close the door gently, so it can open again later

PROMPT · GRACIOUS DECLINE

I have been offered [role] at [organisation] by [name], but I am declining because [the real reason, for your eyes only, such as another offer, location or salary]. I would like to keep a good relationship for the future.

Write a short, sincere email of no more than 120 words. Thank them for the offer and their time. Decline clearly in the first two sentences so there is no doubt. Give a brief, honest but general reason only if it helps the relationship; do not share details I would regret. Say something genuine I valued about the process or team. Leave the door open for future roles. British conventions.

Give two versions: one that mentions a reason and one that does not.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

"For your eyes only" gives the AI context without putting it in the email.

Decline fast. Another candidate may be waiting for that offer.

PROMPTS · SALARY NEGOTIATION

Research the range with Grok, write the ask with Opus 5.5

STEP 1 · GROK · MARKET CHECK

Search current UK adverts for [job title] in [city] at [seniority]. List ten with salary, employer type and date, then give a typical range. Flag anything that looks unreliable. Show your sources.

STEP 2 · OPUS 5.5 · THE ASK

I have been offered [role] at [salary]. The market range I found is [range, with two sources]. My strongest reasons for a higher figure: [skills, experience, competing offer if true]. Write a warm, confident email of no more than 170 words asking for [figure]. Thank them, restate enthusiasm, give two evidence based reasons, make the request, and suggest alternatives if salary is fixed: start date, training budget, hybrid days or an early pay review. No ultimatums. Nothing untrue.

Public sector reality: a Civil Service advert in this study states that new entrants start at the band minimum. NHS and council pay is usually set by grade. Ask about other terms instead.

Never invent a competing offer. It is dishonest and easily tested.

PROMPT · RESIGNATION LETTER

Leave on facts and thanks, never on grievances

PROMPT · CLEAN RESIGNATION

I am resigning from my role as [title] at [employer]. My manager is [name]. My contractual notice period is [x weeks], so my intended last working day is [date]. Any untaken annual leave: [days, or unsure]. Things I genuinely valued: [one or two].

Write a formal resignation letter of no more than 150 words. State the resignation and last working day in the first paragraph. Thank them sincerely and specifically in one or two sentences. Offer to help with a handover. Ask HR to confirm my final pay and leave arrangements. Do not mention complaints, the new job's details or salary. British formal letter conventions.

Check my dates: tell me if my last day does not match the notice period I gave.

TONE DIAL



Warm — Formal

The date check catches the most common mistake: miscounting notice.

Unhappy at work? Raise issues through the proper process, separately. The resignation letter stays clean.

PROMPT · ASKING FOR A REFERENCE

Make it easy for your referee to say yes, and say it well

PROMPT · REFERENCE REQUEST

I want to ask [name, their role, how they know me] to be a referee for [job] at [organisation]. The employer may contact them [when, if known]. Their preferred contact method: [x].

Write a polite message of no more than 140 words asking permission first, not assuming. Include: the role and why I am applying in one sentence; the dates I worked or studied with them; two or three specific things they saw me do that are relevant to this job, as gentle reminders; when they might be contacted. Thank them and make it easy to decline. Then write a 50 word follow up I can send once I know the outcome, thanking them either way.

TONE DIAL



Warm — Formal

Reminders, not a script. Referees write better with prompts, but the words must be theirs.

Why it matters: NHS Lothian specifications mark some criteria R, assessed by reference.

PROMPT · FLEXIBLE WORKING REQUEST

Frame the request around how the work still gets done

PROMPT · STATUTORY STYLE REQUEST

<policy> [paste your employer's flexible working policy, or the key points of the official guidance you have read] </policy>
<request> [the change you want: days, hours, location, start date, and whether temporary or permanent] </request>
<my_role> [main duties, team, how cover works now] </my_role>

Write a formal written request that follows the steps and information required in <policy>. State the change, the date I want it to start, and that this is a flexible working request. Explain how my duties will still be covered and any benefits to the team. Offer a trial period. Keep reasons brief; I do not have to give private details. Professional, positive, British conventions. Then list anything <policy> requires that I have not given you.

Paste the rules. Employment law and policies change; give the AI the current version from your employer, GOV.UK or Citizens Advice rather than relying on its memory.

The trial offer lowers the risk for your manager and often unlocks a yes.

Not legal advice: for disputes, speak to Acas, Citizens Advice or a union.

PROMPT · INTERNAL PROMOTION OR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

They know you already. Show them the next level of you.

PROMPT · STEP UP STATEMENT

<new_role> [advert or role profile for the higher grade] </new_role>
<current_role> [your current job description] </current_role>
<stretch_evidence> [times you acted up, led projects, covered for a manager, trained others, improved a process; appraisal comments] </stretch_evidence>

You are the hiring manager for <new_role>. First, list the three biggest differences between <current_role> and <new_role>. Then write my statement so that each difference is answered with evidence from <stretch_evidence>, showing I already work at the higher level some of the time. Mention any internal programmes the advert asks about, such as a leadership course. Use the organisation's own terms. Within [limit]. Flag any difference I have no evidence for.

The gap analysis stops you describing your current job well and the new one not at all.

Internal adverts in this study include Birmingham's Localities Housing Officer and police promotion boards at Durham and South Yorkshire.

Do not assume the panel remembers your best work. Write it down.

PROMPT · UCAS PERSONAL STATEMENT

Coach mode only: the student writes, the AI asks and checks

PROMPT · PERSONAL STATEMENT COACH

<questions> [paste the exact UCAS questions and character limits shown in your application this cycle] </questions>
<course> [subject and two course pages you are applying to] </course>
<my_draft> [your own first attempt, however rough] </my_draft>

You are an experienced sixth form tutor. Do not rewrite my statement. Instead: 1. For each question, tell me whether my draft answers it and quote my strongest sentence. 2. Ask me up to five questions that would help me add specific evidence: books, projects, work experience, what I learned and how it links to the course. 3. Point out any vague claims. 4. Check my character count against each limit. 5. Suggest where to cut. I will revise and send it back.

New format: UCAS introduced a structured question format for 2026 entry. Always paste the current questions rather than trusting the AI's memory.

Why coach mode: universities expect the statement to be the applicant's own work. A coach keeps it that way.

Parents: this prompt works well sat beside your teenager, reading the questions aloud.

PROMPT · PHD APPLICATION AND RESEARCH STATEMENT

Fit, method, readiness: the three things a supervisor scans for

Best in Opus 5.5

<studentship> [the advert or call: title, aims, funder, eligibility, required documents and limits] </studentship>
<supervisors> [their research summaries and two recent paper abstracts each] </supervisors>
<my_record> [degrees and grades, dissertation, projects, publications, technical skills, relevant work] </my_record> <my_idea> [your rough research idea] </my_idea>
You are a prospective supervisor reviewing applicants. **First**, tell me honestly how well <my_idea> fits the call and the supervisors' work, and suggest two sharper research questions. Wait for my choice. **Then** draft a statement of [limit] covering: motivation rooted in a real moment in my studies; preparation, proving I can do the methods; the proposed question, approach and expected contribution; why this group, citing their real work from <supervisors>; and career aims.
<rules> Cite only papers I pasted. Never invent results, grades or publications. Precise, modest, academic British English. List claims I should double check. </rules>

PROMPT · SCHOLARSHIP OR BURSARY

Answer the funder’s criteria, not the story you wish they asked for

PROMPT · CRITERIA FIRST SCHOLARSHIP ESSAY

<scheme> [scholarship name, purpose, eligibility, selection criteria, questions and limits] </scheme>
<me> [academic record, achievements, community work, leadership, circumstances you choose to share, career goal] </me>

You are on this scholarship’s selection panel. Step 1: list the selection criteria and rank them by how much they seem to matter, based on the wording of <scheme>. Step 2: map my evidence to each. Step 3: draft the answer to each question within its limit, leading with the criteria the funder weighs most. Explain how the award would make a specific difference and what I would give back. Dignified, factual, never pleading. Use only what is in <me>.

Ranking the criteria reveals what the funder really wants: merit, need, leadership or subject fit.

“Specific difference”: name what the money changes, such as fewer paid hours and more research time.

Circumstances: share only what you choose. Dignity reads stronger than detail.

PROMPT · SMALL GRANT OR FUNDING BID

Need, plan, outcomes, budget: what every funder scores

PROMPT · GRANT APPLICATION DRAFT

<guidance> [the funder's priorities, eligibility, questions, limits and scoring notes] </guidance>
<project> [who you help, the problem with any local evidence, what you will do, timeline, who delivers it, partners] </project>
<budget> [line items and amounts] </budget>

You are an experienced grants assessor for this funder. Answer each question in <guidance> within its limit, using the funder's own priority words where they genuinely apply. Show: the need with evidence; the activities; measurable outcomes and how we will record them; why our group is trusted to deliver; and how every budget line links to an activity. Check the budget adds up and flag any eligible cost I have missed or ineligible cost I included.

Outputs versus outcomes: "12 sessions" is an output; "20 parents report more confidence" is an outcome. Funders want both.

Budget check: AI arithmetic can slip. Recalculate totals in a spreadsheet.

Grok first: ask it to find local statistics with sources to evidence the need.

PROMPT · VOLUNTEER APPLICATION

Short, sincere, reliable: what volunteer coordinators look for

PROMPT · VOLUNTEER ANSWERS

I am applying to volunteer as [role] with [organisation]. The form asks: [paste each question and limit]. About me: [why this cause matters to me, my availability, relevant skills, any experience with the people they support, any checks I already hold].

Write a short answer to each question in a warm, sincere, plain voice. Be specific about availability and how reliable I am. Connect my motivation to their mission in one honest sentence, without sounding grand. If the role involves children or vulnerable adults, include a sentence showing I understand safeguarding. Keep each answer within its limit.

TONE DIAL



Warm — Formal

Reliability is the hidden criterion. Coordinators plan rotas around you.

Career bridge: museum and charity volunteering counted as real experience in several adverts we studied.

PROMPT · APPRENTICESHIP APPLICATION

Potential over experience: prove you will learn and stay

PROMPT · APPRENTICE APPLICATION

<vacancy> [advert, apprenticeship standard and level, employer, training provider, questions on the form] </vacancy>
<me> [school or college results, part time jobs, hobbies that show skill or commitment, anything you have taught yourself, why this career] </me>

You are an apprenticeship recruiter. Answer each question on the form within its limit. Focus on evidence of attitude and potential: turning up reliably, learning something new on my own, finishing what I start, working with others. Show I understand the apprenticeship mixes work with study and that I am ready for both. Mention something specific about this employer. Plain, enthusiastic but natural British English, written as a young person would speak at their best.

Real example: Barnwood Park's teaching assistant apprenticeship asked directly what attracted applicants to the role.

Self teaching counts: building a gaming PC or running a social account shows initiative.

Firefighters too: Royal Berkshire recruits wholetime firefighters through an apprenticeship route.

PROMPT · FORMAL COMPLAINT LETTER

Facts, impact, remedy, deadline. Anger stays out of it.

PROMPT · CALM, FIRM COMPLAINT

<policy> [the organisation's complaints procedure, if published] </policy>
<timeline> [dates, who you spoke to, reference numbers, what was promised, what happened] </timeline>
<impact> [cost, time lost, stress, inconvenience] </impact> <remedy> [what you want] </remedy>

Write a formal complaint letter of no more than 350 words, following <policy> if given. Open by stating this is a formal complaint and quoting my reference numbers. Set out the facts in date order, briefly and without emotion. Describe the impact. State exactly what I want and a reasonable response deadline. List the documents I am attaching. Say politely that I will use the next stage of the procedure if unresolved. British formal conventions. Use only facts from my notes.

TONE DIAL



Warm Formal

Vent first, separately. Write the angry version for yourself, then give the AI only the facts.

Escalation: ask Grok to find the right ombudsman or regulator for your sector, with sources.

PROMPT · APPEAL LETTER

Appeal on the permitted grounds, with evidence, on time

PROMPT · GROUNDS BASED APPEAL

<decision> [the decision letter you are appealing, such as an academic result, a shortlisting outcome you are entitled to query, or a council decision] </decision>
<rules> [the appeal procedure: allowed grounds, deadline, form, evidence required] </rules>
<my_case> [what happened, why you think the decision is wrong, the evidence you hold] </my_case>

First, tell me honestly which of the allowed grounds in <rules> my case fits, and which it does not. Wait for me. Then write the appeal: identify the decision and date; state each ground I am using, in the procedure's own words; give the facts and evidence for each; state the outcome I am asking for. Respectful, precise, no exaggeration. Remind me of the deadline.

Grounds decide everything. Many appeals fail because they argue disagreement, not a permitted ground such as procedural error or new evidence.

The honesty check may save you from an appeal that cannot succeed.

Serious matters: get free advice from Citizens Advice or your students' union as well.

THE LETTER TONE MATRIX

Ten letters at a glance: length, tone, must have, never

Letter	Words	Tone	Must include	Never
Cover letter	up to 300	Confident	Best proof, two matches, why them	“I am writing to apply”
Speculative	up to 200	Warm	Specific reason, modest ask	Demanding a job
Follow up	up to 100	Polite	Reference number, one strength	Impatience
Thank you	up to 150	Warm	One topic discussed	Re arguing answers
Acceptance	up to 180	Warm	Exact terms, conditions	Rounded figures
Decline	up to 120	Gracious	Clear no, door open	Over sharing
Salary ask	up to 170	Confident	Evidence, alternatives	Ultimatums, fake offers
Resignation	up to 150	Formal	Last day, thanks, handover	Grievances
Reference ask	up to 140	Warm	Permission, reminders	Writing it for them
Complaint	up to 350	Firm	Facts, remedy, deadline	Anger, insults

Word counts are this guide’s working suggestions, not rules. Any limit set by the organisation always wins.

PART FIVE

5 Interview preparation prompts

Statements get you into the room. These prompts turn the AI into a question setter, a sparring partner and a strict but fair panel, so you walk in having already answered the hard questions out loud.

Question banks | STAR builder | Mock panels | Strengths | Values | Technical | Presentations | **Debrief**

Six UK interview styles seen across the 104 adverts

Behaviour based

“Tell me about a time…” Civil Service, councils, universities. Answer with STAR.

Strengths based

Quick questions on what energises you. DWP blended interviews mixed strengths and behaviours.

Values based

NHS trusts, charities, TfGM: how you act when values are tested.

Framework based

Police interviews assessed against the CVF; fire services against their own frameworks.

Technical

Machine learning, engineering and clinical skills: explain, solve, defend choices.

Assessment day

Presentations, group exercises and tests: fire services, prisons, senior roles.

Prompt habit: always tell the AI which format your invitation describes, and paste the invitation letter itself.

PROMPT · THE QUESTION BANK BUILDER

Predict the questions from the paperwork you already have

PROMPT · LIKELY QUESTIONS

<invitation> [the interview invitation: format, panel, timing, any presentation or test] </invitation>
<job_pack> [advert, person spec, values or behaviours named] </job_pack>
<my_statement> [the statement or CV you submitted] </my_statement>

You are the panel chair. Build a bank of 20 likely questions in four groups: 1. criteria or behaviour questions, one or two per criterion; 2. values or strengths questions if the format suggests them; 3. probing follow ups on claims in <my_statement>, the ones a sharp panel would test; 4. motivation and knowledge questions about this employer. For each question, note in one line what a strong answer must show. Mark the five you think are most likely.

Group 3 is gold. Panels read your statement and probe it. Prepare to go deeper on every claim.

DWP example: a blended interview of three strength and three behaviour questions was described in one Work Coach advert.

Then: take the top five into the STAR builder on the next slide.

PROMPT · STAR ANSWER BUILDER FOR SPEAKING

Spoken answers are not written statements read aloud

PROMPT · TWO MINUTE ANSWER

Question I expect: [paste]. The story I want to use: [paste from evidence bank]. What the panel is looking for: [paste from the question bank or criteria].

Turn this into an answer I can say aloud in about two minutes, roughly 250 to 300 spoken words. Use short sentences and natural spoken British English. Start with a one sentence headline that answers the question. Then STAR, with most of the time on my actions and my reasoning. End with the result and one line of reflection.

Below it, give me a five word memory cue for each STAR part, so I can remember the shape rather than memorising a script. Then list two follow up questions a panel might ask about this story, with a short note on how to answer each.

Headline first: panels relax when they hear the answer before the story.

Memory cues, not scripts. Recited answers sound rehearsed and collapse under a follow up.

Time yourself. Say it aloud with a phone timer. Two minutes is longer than it sounds.

Written versus spoken: what the prompt changes

Feature	Written statement	Spoken answer
Opening	Criterion label	One sentence headline answer
Sentences	Up to 25 words	Short, under 15 words
Detail	Dense, every word earns marks	Fewer details, more reasoning
Ending	Result with figure	Result plus one reflection
Preparation	Final polished text	Memory cues and rehearsal
Risk	Missing a criterion	Rambling past two minutes

Reasoning is the spoken bonus. In speech you can say why you chose an action, which shows judgement panels love.

Voice practice: use the voice mode in either app to hear your answer read back, then say it yourself.

PROMPT · THE MOCK INTERVIEW PANEL

A full rehearsal, one question at a time, scored honestly

Use voice mode

<job_pack> [advert, person spec, values] </job_pack> <format> [from the invitation: length, panel, question types] </format>

You are a panel of two: [role, such as the hiring manager] and [role, such as an HR adviser]. Run a realistic mock interview for this job in the format described.

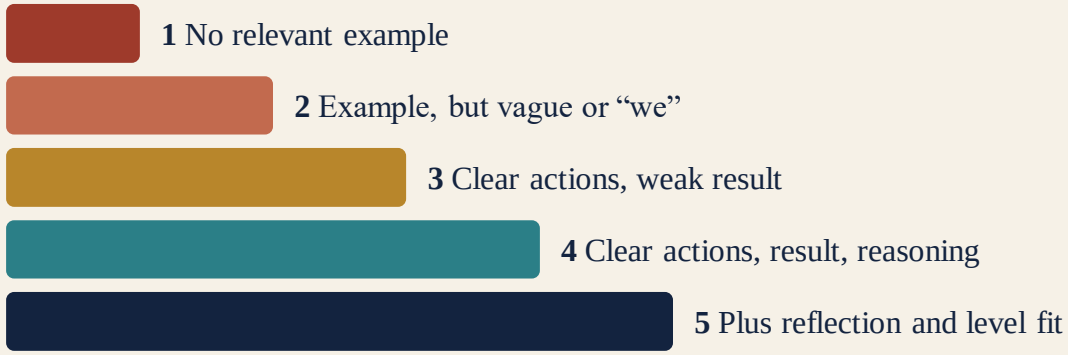
Rules of the session:

1. Ask one question at a time and wait for my answer. Never answer for me.
2. Ask one natural follow up if my answer is vague, as a real panel would.
3. Do not give feedback until I type FEEDBACK, so the interview flows.
4. Ask six to eight questions, mixing types as the format suggests.

When I type FEEDBACK: score each answer from 1 to 5 against what the job pack needs, quote the strongest and weakest line I said, name one specific improvement for each, and finish with my three biggest patterns, good and bad. Be honest and specific; encouraging, never flattering.

Why “wait for FEEDBACK” makes the rehearsal feel real

THE 1 TO 5 LADDER TO ASK FOR



One at a time: mirrors the real pressure of thinking on your feet.

Follow ups: the questions that catch people out are the second ones.

Quoted lines: feedback on your exact words is far more useful than general advice.

“Never flattering”: add it every time. Without it, feedback tends to be too kind to be useful.

This ladder is a practice tool. Real panels use their own scales, such as the 1 to 7 Civil Service scale.

PROMPT · STRENGTHS INTERVIEW PRACTICE

Fast, genuine, energised: there is no STAR here

PROMPT · RAPID FIRE STRENGTHS

I have a Civil Service interview that includes strength based questions for [role and grade]. Explain briefly how strengths questions differ from behaviour questions. Then ask me ten quick strengths style questions, one at a time, such as what I enjoy, what drains me, what I do when I have spare time at work. Wait for each answer. I will answer quickly and honestly, as in the real thing.

After all ten, tell me: which answers sounded genuine and energised; which sounded rehearsed or generic; and which strengths my answers revealed that fit this role. Do not tell me what to say. Help me notice what is true about me.

Why not script these? Strengths questions explore what motivates you. Authentic, quick answers score; rehearsed ones fall flat.

Seen in this study: DWP Work Coach adverts assessed strengths at interview; HMPPS assesses strengths for prison officers too.

Do it out loud in voice mode. Speed is part of the test.

PROMPT · NHS VALUES BASED INTERVIEW

Rehearse the moments when values are under pressure

PROMPT · VALUES SCENARIOS

<trust_values> [paste the trust's values exactly] </trust_values> <role> [job title and band] </role>

You are an NHS interview panel. For each value, ask me one question, either about a past experience or a realistic scenario for this role, such as a colleague being disrespectful to a patient, a family upset about waiting, or a mistake I notice I have made. One at a time; wait for my answer.

After each answer, tell me: did I put the patient first; did I act safely and within my role; did I escalate appropriately; was I honest and open, especially about mistakes; and which value my answer showed most clearly. Suggest one sentence I could add. Keep advice consistent with general professional standards; tell me to check my trust's own policies for specifics.

The mistake question is common in clinical interviews. Openness and learning score; hiding scores badly.

Within your role: support workers escalate to registered staff. Say so.

Policy check line stops the AI inventing a procedure your trust does not use.

PROMPT · POLICE AND FIRE INTERVIEWS

Framework interviews: every answer mapped before you walk in

PROMPT · FRAMEWORK MOCK

<framework> [the CVF competencies and values, or the fire service's values and behaviours, with any level descriptors] </framework>
<my_stories> [evidence bank] </my_stories>

You are an assessor for [force or fire and rescue service]. Ask me one interview question for each competency or value in <framework>, in a random order, one at a time. After each answer, rate it against the listed indicators, tell me which indicators I demonstrated and which I missed, and ask one follow up question exactly as a real assessor might. At the end, give me a table: competency, story I used, rating, missing indicator. Warn me if I reused the same story.

Random order stops you preparing in a neat sequence the real panel will not follow.

Indicators, not impressions: CVF assessors score observable behaviours. So should your practice.

Fire services such as Royal Berkshire add group exercises and physical tests. See slide 146.

PROMPT · TECHNICAL INTERVIEW, MACHINE LEARNING EXAMPLE

Explain clearly, defend choices, admit limits

PROMPT · TECHNICAL SPARRING PARTNER

<job_ad> [paste] </job_ad> <my_projects> [two projects: goal, data, model, deployment, results, what went wrong] </my_projects>

You are a senior machine learning engineer interviewing me for this role. Run a 30 minute technical conversation, one question at a time: start with a walk through of one project, then probe my choices (why this model, how I evaluated it, how I handled imbalance or drift), then one system design question based on the advert's needs, such as deploying a model with monitoring and governance. Push back when my answer is shallow. At the end, list the concepts I explained well, the ones I should revise, and three resources to revise them.

Do not give me the answers during the interview.

"What went wrong" in the input lets the AI probe honestly, as real interviewers do.

Swap the field: replace machine learning with nursing skills, engineering or finance; the structure holds.

Admitting limits well beats bluffing. Practise saying "I have not used that, but here is how I would approach it."

PROMPT · INTERVIEW PRESENTATION TASK

Ten minutes, one clear message, ready for questions

PROMPT · PRESENTATION COACH

My interview includes a [10] minute presentation on: "[exact title from the invitation]". Audience: [panel roles]. Format allowed: [slides, handout, none]. The role: [paste the job summary].

1. Tell me what the panel is most likely testing with this title.
2. Propose a structure of no more than five sections with timings that add up to [10] minutes, leaving one minute spare.
3. For each section, give the key point in one sentence and the evidence or example I should use; mark where I must supply my own facts.
4. Suggest no more than six slides, each with a headline and one visual idea.
5. List eight likely panel questions afterwards.
6. Write a 30 second opening and closing I can learn.

"What are they testing?" A presentation on improving a service tests planning and judgement, not your slide design.

One minute spare: real talks overrun. Panels often stop you at time.

Then rehearse with the mock panel prompt, starting from the questions in step 5.

PROMPT · THE TOUGH QUESTIONS

Weaknesses, gaps, leaving, failure: honest answers that still win

PROMPT · TOUGH QUESTION DRILL

Here are the honest facts behind the questions I dread: [a real weakness and what you do about it; any gap in employment; why you are leaving your job; a time you failed; why you have moved jobs often, if relevant]. The role: [title and sector].

For each, write a spoken answer of about one minute using this shape: acknowledge it plainly, give the context briefly, show what I did or learned, and bridge to why I am ready for this role now. Keep it honest; never turn a weakness into a disguised strength such as “I work too hard”. Never criticise a past employer. Then ask me each question in turn so I can practise aloud, and tell me if I sounded defensive.

THE FOUR BEAT SHAPE

Acknowledge · Context · Action · Bridge

The fake weakness is the oldest trick in the book. Panels see through it at once.

Defensive check: asking the AI to flag defensiveness catches the tone you cannot hear yourself.

PROMPT · YOUR QUESTIONS FOR THE PANEL

The last five minutes are still part of the interview

PROMPT · SMART QUESTIONS · GREAT IN GROK

I have an interview for [role] at [organisation] on [date]. Search for recent, reliable news about the organisation and this service, and summarise three developments with sources.

Then suggest eight questions I could ask the panel, in three groups: the role (what success looks like in the first six months); the team and support (training, supervision, how the team works); the organisation (how a recent development affects this team). Avoid anything answered in the job pack I pasted: [paste]. Avoid salary and holiday questions at this stage. Mark the two strongest.

Why Grok here: its access to current web results suits questions that show you follow the organisation's news.

Check every source. Asking about news that is wrong or out of date backfires.

Two is enough. Ask your best two, and listen properly to the answers.

PROMPT · ASSESSMENT CENTRE AND GROUP EXERCISE

Assessors watch how you work with others, not who talks most

PROMPT · GROUP EXERCISE REHEARSAL

I have an assessment day for [role] at [organisation], including a group exercise. What I know about it: [any details from the invitation]. The behaviours or values being assessed: [paste].

1. Explain what assessors typically observe in group exercises and how that links to the behaviours listed.
2. Create a realistic practice scenario with a short brief and four other candidates with different styles: a dominant talker, a quiet expert, a time watcher and a sceptic.
3. Run the discussion, playing all four candidates, and pause after each of their turns for my contribution.
4. Afterwards, give feedback on how I included others, built on ideas, kept to time and helped reach a decision.

In this study: Royal Berkshire's firefighter timeline included a group exercise; HMPPS uses an online assessment centre.

Bringing in the quiet expert often earns more marks than winning the argument.

The four characters let you rehearse the hardest group dynamics in your living room.

Win or lose, every interview should make the next one easier

PROMPT A · SAME DAY DEBRIEF

I have just finished an interview for [role]. Here is everything I remember: the questions, roughly what I said, the panel's reactions, what I forgot to mention. Organise this into: questions asked; my strongest answers; weakest answers with a better version from my evidence bank; new questions to add to my question bank; one change for next time. Save it as a short report I can reread before my next interview.

PROMPT B · ASKING FOR FEEDBACK

I was not successful for [role and reference] at [organisation]. Write a short, gracious email of no more than 100 words to [contact] thanking them, asking if they could share brief feedback on how my application or interview compared with the criteria, and saying I would welcome future opportunities. No disappointment, no argument.

Do the debrief within an hour. Memory of exact questions fades fast.

Reserve lists: several adverts held candidates for up to 12 months. A gracious reply keeps you in mind.

PROMPT · THE DAY BEFORE

A calm plan beats a late night of cramming

PROMPT · INTERVIEW EVE PLANNER

My interview is tomorrow at [time] at [place, or online via a named platform]. It is [format]. I need to bring: [anything listed in the invitation, such as identity documents or certificates]. I tend to feel nervous about: [x].

Make me a simple plan: 1. a checklist of documents and items from my invitation; 2. a travel or tech check with a 30 minute buffer; 3. a 45 minute evening review covering my five key stories, my two questions for the panel and my opening answer to “tell us about yourself”; 4. three practical techniques for calming nerves before going in; 5. a one page summary sheet I can read on the morning. Keep it short and practical.

Documents matter: right to work and identity checks were mentioned across many adverts in this study.

Adjustments: Civil Service and HMPPS adverts invite requests for reasonable adjustments. Ask early, not on the day.

Sleep is preparation. Stop reviewing at a set time.

PART SIX

6 Advanced techniques and the quick reference

Chain prompts into a pipeline, let the AI play the sift panel, remove the tells that make text sound machine made, repair bad drafts quickly, and build a personal library you reuse for years.

TECHNIQUE · THE PROMPT PIPELINE

Five small prompts beat one giant one

1
Decode
Advert decoder, slide 47

→

2
Map
Criteria to stories table, approved by you

→

3
Draft
Sector prompt from Part 3

→

4
Judge
Sift simulator, slide 151

→

5
Polish
Voice match, slide 152

Why chain? Each step has one job, so each is easier for the model to do well and easier for you to check.

Same chat or new? Steps 1 to 3 in one chat keep context. Run step 4 in a fresh chat, or the other model, for an unbiased judge.

Anthropic's docs recommend chaining complex prompts into steps. This is that idea, made practical.

PROMPT · THE SIFT PANEL SIMULATOR

Three markers, one statement, no mercy

Run in a fresh chat

<criteria> [the person specification or behaviours, with the scoring scale if known] </criteria> <statement> [your final draft] </statement>

Simulate a sift panel of three independent markers who have read 60 statements today:

Marker 1, the strict one: scores only explicit evidence; ignores claims without examples.

Marker 2, the specialist: knows the job well and spots shallow or wrong sector language.

Marker 3, the tired one: skims; scores only what is easy to find.

Each marker scores every criterion separately, with one sentence of reasoning. Then give the agreed panel score, say whether this statement would likely be shortlisted against strong competition, and list the three changes that would raise the score most. Do not rewrite the statement. Do not soften the verdict.

Three personas expose three different weaknesses: missing evidence, wrong language, buried proof.

A simulation, not a prediction. Use it to improve, never as a promise of the outcome.

PROMPT · MAKE IT SOUND LIKE YOU

Strip out machine tells, put your voice back in

PROMPT · VOICE PASS

<my_writing> [three paragraphs you wrote without AI: an email, a past statement, a message to a colleague] </my_writing>
<draft> [the AI assisted draft] </draft>

First, describe my natural style from <my_writing> in five bullet points: sentence length, vocabulary, formality, rhythm, habits. Then edit <draft> to match that style. Remove phrases that sound generated: grand openings, triple adjectives, repeated sentence patterns, “not only but also”, “a testament to”, “delve”, “seamless”, “in today’s fast paced world”. Keep every fact and every criterion. Do not add anything new. Finally, list each change you made and why, so I can accept or reject it.

Not a disguise. The goal is your genuine voice, so the panel meets the same person on paper and in the room.

The change list keeps you in control of every edit.

Final test: read it aloud. If you would not say a sentence, change it yourself.

THE REPAIR KIT

Bad draft? Diagnose the symptom, paste the fix

SYMPTOM · too long

“Cut to [N] words. Keep every criterion and every number. Show what you removed.”

SYMPTOM · generic

“Replace every general claim with a specific example from my evidence, or delete it.”

SYMPTOM · invented facts

“List every fact not found in my evidence. Remove them all and mark gaps.”

SYMPTOM · too grand

“Rewrite in plain words I would use at work. Shorter sentences. No adjectives of praise.”

SYMPTOM · “we” everywhere

“Rewrite so my own actions are clear. Use ‘I’ for what I did; mention the team only for context.”

SYMPTOM · missed criterion

“Check against the spec line by line. Add a paragraph for each criterion not addressed.”

SYMPTOM · weak results

“For each example, ask me one question that would give a measurable result.”

SYMPTOM · going in circles

Start a new chat. Paste the best version and only the essential rules.

Why a new chat helps: long conversations accumulate old drafts and instructions. A clean start with clear inputs often fixes stubborn problems at once.

BUILD YOUR PERSONAL PROMPT LIBRARY

Write each prompt once. Reuse it for every application.



Where: one document or notes page, one heading per prompt, brackets for the parts you change.

Claude: keep the evidence bank in a project so it is always to hand.

Grok: put your standing rules in custom instructions.

Version your prompts. When a tweak improves results, save it as version 2 with a one line note on what changed. In six months you will have a toolkit nobody else has.

THE QUICK REFERENCE CARD

Everything in this deck, on one screen

EIGHT BLOCKS

1 Role · 2 Goal · 3 Context · 4 Source material · 5 Evidence · 6 Constraints · 7 Format · 8 Quality check

FIVE GOLDEN RULES

Paste the full person spec · only your facts, mark gaps · “I” not “we” · state the exact limit · you read the final version

OPUS 5.5

Labelled tags · long documents first · examples in example tags · plan, then write, then check · output in named boxes · best for final drafts and letters

GROK

Direct, conversational brief · capital headings · “formal, no jokes” · say when not to search · fence the length · best for research and blunt critique

Pipeline: decode 47 · map · draft by sector 49 to 105 · judge 151 · polish 152

Interviews: question bank 134 · STAR builder 135 · mock panel 137 · debrief 147

Honesty: employers check. Write what you can defend in the room.

Adverts 1 to 26 · NHS clinical, support and administration

01 Barking, Havering and Redbridge · Staff Nurse, ward
02 Barking, Havering and Redbridge · Staff Nurse, team
03 University Hospitals Birmingham · RN, infectious disease
04 NHS Lothian · Staff Nurse, discharge hub
05 NHS Lothian · Staff Nurse, ENT outpatients
06 NHS Lothian · Care Home Team Staff Nurse
07 NHS Lothian · Staff Nurse, general medicine
08 Dorset HealthCare · Band 6 Specialist Practitioner
09 Berkshire Healthcare via NHSP · Band 6 practitioner
10 Sussex Partnership · Band 7 Specialist Practitioner
11 Newcastle upon Tyne Hospitals · Nurse Specialist
12 Crisis service, Devizes · Band 6 Intensive Practitioner
13 Nottinghamshire Healthcare · MHST Practitioner
14 Black Country Healthcare · HCSW Band 3
15 Barts Health, Royal London · Senior HCSW, theatres
16 Barts Health, Newham · Senior HCSW
17 Birmingham, Heartlands · Band 2 or 3 HCA
18 Great Western Hospitals · Senior HCSW
19 Portsmouth Hospitals · HCSW Band 2 or 3
20 Epsom and St Helier · HCSW Band 3
21 Birmingham · Medical Secretary Supervisor
22 Birmingham · Medical Secretary, hands
23 North Cumbria Integrated Care · Medical Secretary
24 Tees, Esk and Wear Valleys · Senior Administrator
25 Dorset HealthCare · Medical Secretary
26 Hertfordshire Partnership · Senior Team Administrator

Sources: NHS Jobs and partner job boards, 2025 to 2026 · many adverts have since closed

Adverts 27 to 52 · Civil Service, justice, fire and Manchester

27 Ministry of Justice · Data Scientist, HEO
28 Ministry of Justice · Data Scientist (Python)
29 Government Office for Science · Data Scientist
30 DWP · Bilingual Work Coach
31 DWP · Bilingual Work Coach, later round
32 DWP, Galashiels · Universal Credit Work Coach
33 DWP, Wales and Marches · Work Coach
34 DWP, South England · Work Coach
35 DWP, North West · Work Coach Team Leader
36 HMRC, Glasgow · Payments Officer, backshift
37 HMRC, Glasgow · Payments Administrative Officer
38 HMRC · Core Services Hub Officer
39 HMRC · Surge and Rapid Response AO
40 HMRC, Worthing · Payments Administrative Officer
41 HMPPS · Prison Officer, male prisons
42 HMPPS · Prison Officer, women’s prisons
43 HMPPS · Prison Officer Returners
44 Durham Constabulary · External promotion
45 South Yorkshire Police · Inspector promotion
46 Police Scotland · Police staff posts
47 Devon, Cornwall and Dorset · Police staff
48 Royal Berkshire FRS · Firefighter apprentice
49 Merseyside FRS · Wholetime Firefighter
50 Oxfordshire FRS · Wholetime Firefighter
51 Leicestershire FRS · Support staff
52 Manchester City Council · Customer Service Advisor

Sources: Civil Service Jobs, HMRC and Justice careers, police, fire and council portals, 2025 to 2026

Adverts 53 to 78 · councils, culture and universities

53 Manchester City Council · Business Support Officer
54 Manchester City Council · CATEC Support Officer
55 Manchester City Council · Administrative Officer
56 Manchester City Council · Business Support L1
57 Manchester City Council · Highways Technical Officer
58 Brighton and Hove · Rehousing Officer
59 Fife Council · Housing Management Officer
60 Fife Council · Housing Options Officer
61 Birmingham City Council · Localities Housing Officer
62 Birmingham City Council · Housing Officer
63 Stockport Council · Experienced Social Worker
64 Coventry City Council · Adult Social Worker
65 Kent County Council · Social Worker

66 Leicestershire County Council · Volunteering Officer
67 Chesterfield Borough Council · Collections Officer
68 Erewash Borough Council · Heritage Officer
69 Rutland County Council · Museum Officer
70 St Helens Borough Council · Creative Programme
71 Bridgwater Town Council · Museum and Heritage
72 University of Worcester · Business and HR
73 University of Worcester · Psychology
74 University of Worcester · FE and Skills
75 University of Worcester · English Language
76 Lancaster University · Sociolinguistics
77 Lancaster University · Social Statistics
78 Lancaster University · International Strategy

Sources: council job portals, Find a Job, university vacancy sites and jobs.ac.uk, 2025 to 2026

APPENDIX · ADVERT INDEX · 4 OF 4

Adverts 79 to 104 · universities, schools, charities, transport, tech

79 Lancaster University · Pharmacology
80 University of Manchester · Research Associate, ML
81 University of Manchester · Foundation Studies
82 University of Manchester · Operations Assistant
83 University of Manchester · PGR Administrator
84 University of Manchester · Division Administrator
85 Manchester Metropolitan · PGR Support
86 Manchester Metropolitan · Education Services
87 Primary school · Teaching Assistant L1
88 Barnwood Park School · TA Apprentice
89 North Yorkshire school · Learning Support
90 College near Wigan · Engineering Lecturer
91 Greater Manchester college · Business Lecturer
92 Greater Manchester college · Computing Lecturer
93 St Mungo's · Support Worker
94 Single Homeless Project · Project Worker
95 Children's charity · Youth Project Worker
96 TfGM · Bee Network Operational Assistant
97 GMCA for TfGM · Graduate Planner
98 TfGM · Senior Revenue Accountant
99 TfGM · Active Travel Network Officer
100 Robert Walters client · ML Engineer
101 UrbanChain · ML Engineer or Data Scientist
102 Gravitas client · Senior MLOps Engineer
103 ECOM client · Senior ML Engineer
104 Adria Solutions client · Junior AI Engineer

Sources: university sites, Teaching Vacancies, CharityJob, Find a Job and recruiter listings, 2025 to 2026

THE LAST WORD

The best prompt in the world still needs your true story.

Gather your evidence, brief the model like a professional, check every line, and walk into the room as the person on the page.

Start here: slide 22, build your evidence bank

Then: slide 47, decode your next advert

Good luck.